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LOSING GROUND

Connecticut's Small Farms Face an Uncertain Future **page 24**

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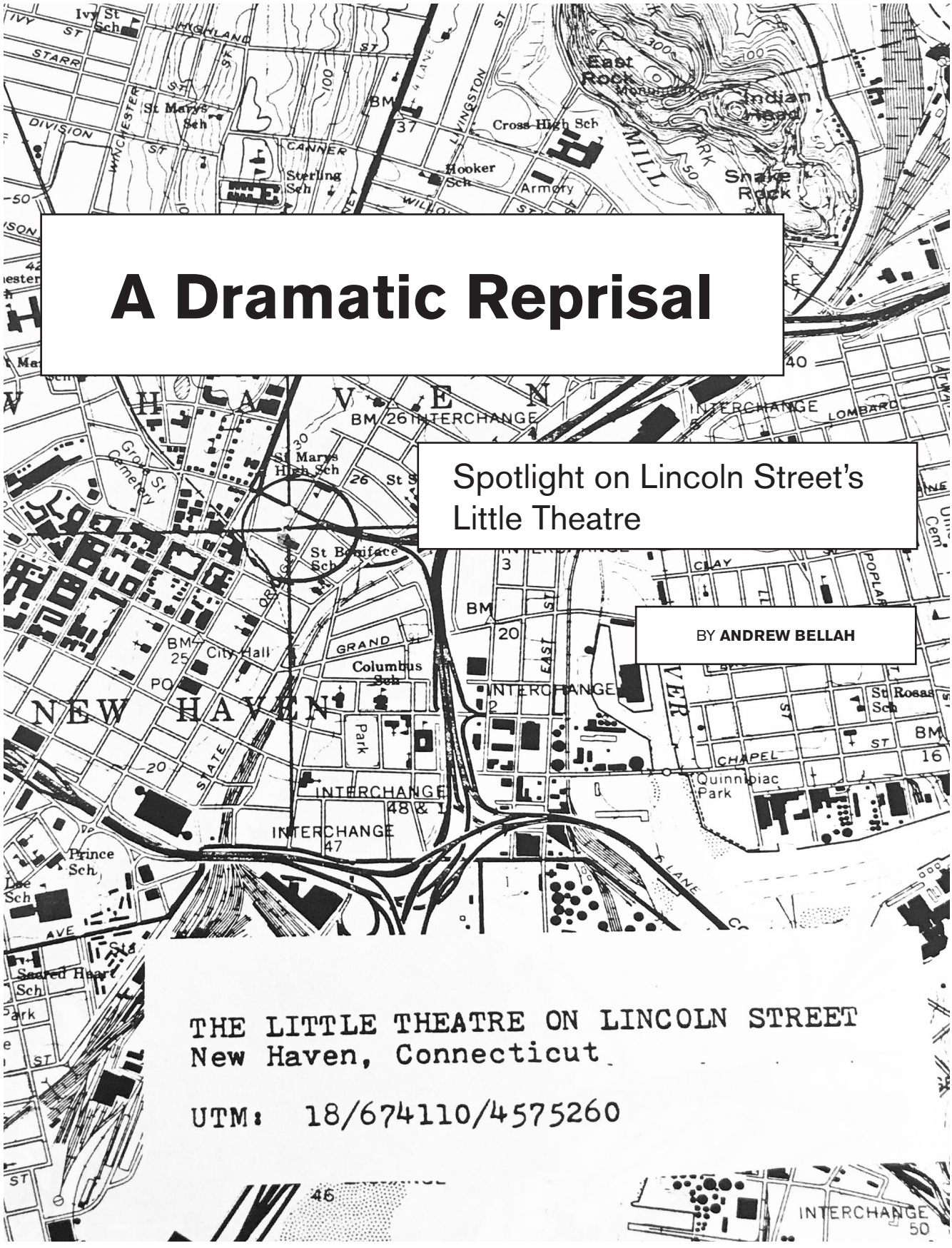
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A Dramatic Reprisal

Spotlight on Lincoln Street's Little Theatre

BY **ANDREW BELLAH**

IT STARTS WITH A SMASH HIT and roaring applause. Eleven members of the newly formed New Haven Theatre Guild join hands for a bow at Sprague Hall; audience members clap for their friends, family, and neighbors on stage. The curtains are drawn, but the crowd refuses to leave, instead erupting into a standing ovation for the community theater's production of *The Admirable Crichton.*

On the following day, June 4, 1922, the *New Haven Register* declared: "Local Theatre Guild's First Performance Gives Promise of Bright Future." The front page included a picture of the cast, taken after their last performance of the weekend.

The black-and-white photo captures 11 cast members dressed in eclectic homemade costumes with faux jaguar pelts and assorted flowers; one boy sports larger-than-life fake sideburns glued to his cheeks. The *Register's* report of the performance praised Ms. Archie Gile, who played the part of Lady Mary Lasenby, and Lewis P. Curtis, who played the Crichton, finally concluding that the "new amateur dramatic organization...will certainly produce more interesting plays."

Little did the actors know that the New Haven Theatre Guild would soon live up to the report's prediction: over the next century, the 11-member group would transform into a thousand-member guild. It would come to play a key role in the Little Theatre Movement, which has continued to define American community drama into the modern day. Over the next century, the Guild's home at the Little Theatre on Lincoln Street would house hundreds of plays and face rises and falls, teetering on the brink of closure more than once. But the New Haven community's consistent and fervent support helped the theater flourish at its sensational peaks and survive its tragic lows.

"AT LAST, WE HAVE a definite proposal in regard to a home for the little theater," reads a 1924 letter from the Guild addressed to New Haven resident Ms. Clare Crawford. "As you may know," it continued, "this is a critical period for the life of the guild. Its work may not continue without a permanent headquarters."

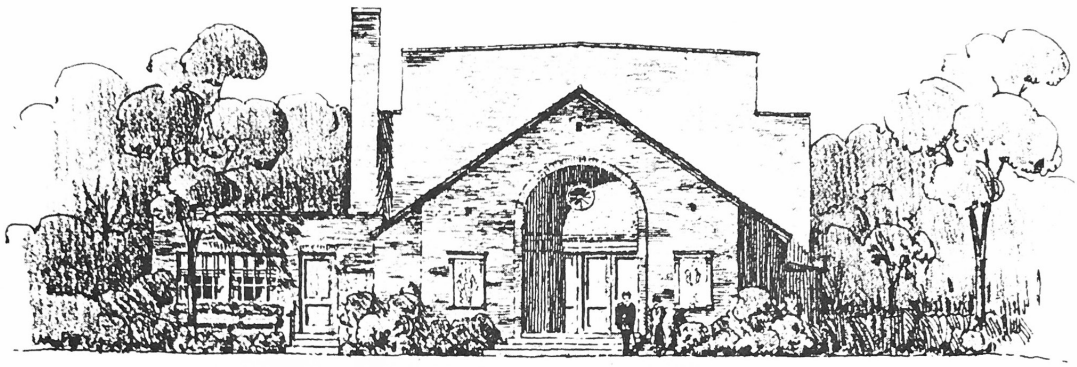
In just its first two years, from 1922 to 1924, the Guild had rapidly expanded, accruing over 100 new members, and the group began pushing for a free-standing theater of its own to replace its previous temporary home in Sprague Hall. In his letters, Guild President William L. Phelps attributed this growth to the group's new repertoire, which included British dramas such as *Everyman* and *Gammer Gurton's Needle*, as well as community favorites like *Alice in Wonderland* and *Snow White and the Seven Dwarfs*. The expansion of the Guild's membership proved to be too much for Sprague, and the executive board of the newly renamed Little Theatre Guild soon set their eyes on collecting dues and pooling funds to construct a new, permanent home.

In 1924, they found their location: an oddly secluded cul-de-sac in a residential neighborhood on a side street off Hillhouse Avenue. There, the Guild built their theater and aptly named it the Little Theatre on Lincoln Street. It is now known simply as the Lincoln Theatre.

Today, the Little Theatre on Lincoln Street remains honest to its name. Surrounded by brick duplexes and small houses, the theater blends in with the surrounding environment almost too well. It has a simple peaked roof and a flat facade with a recessed semi-circle arch over its double doors. The only mark that distinguishes it from the houses is a simple black-font banner that reads, "LITTLE LINCOLN THEATRE."

AT ITS PEAK, the Guild was one of the most popular volunteer organizations in New Haven. It counted nearly 1,000 adults and over 130 children as members by 1930, according to the *Register.*

By 1934, the Guild produced its first official mission statement toward creating an "effective and lively community center for the arts." A hand-drawn picture of the the-



THE LITTLE THEATRE
LINCOLN STREET

PHOTOS VIA **NEW HAVEN MUSEUM**



"The theater was as dingy as ever, but what will we do without it?"

ater at the time accompanied the mailer and depicted the theater with a second story above its peaked roof, huge pine trees flanking its double doors, and flower beds out front. By the door, there once were huge display cases that would have held posters advertising performances. These cases were a far cry from the fliers for long-past performances in the singular steel-and-glass box by the door that I saw on my first visit. Somehow, sometime since this drawing was made, the Little Theatre had lost the life it had garnered from loyal patrons and thespians.

The theater's archives offer a glimpse into some of the Lincoln Theatre's most successful nights. After its first performances, for instance, the Guild hosted local beauty pageants and held a gypsy costume party in a local park. The theater eventually featured everything from starchy English plays to comedies like *The Romantic Age* by A. A. Miles and *He Who Gets Slapped* by Leonid Andreyev, which came with an amazing collection of black-and-white pictures of boys dressed in whimsical clown costumes.

By 1934, the peak of its heyday, the Little Theatre on Lincoln had presented over 60 plays by many well-known authors, had established its own children's theater, and was putting on five productions per season, with special classes for children in diction and speaking, puppetry, and eurythmics. Additionally, it had organized for two years a series of children's orchestra concerts directed by professionals from the Yale School of Music, and it had started branching out to foreign films from Europe at a price of one dollar per ticket.

It seemed that the Little Theatre on Lincoln was on track to become the Big Theatre on Lincoln. But soon enough, the community found it increasingly difficult to sustain the theater's rapid growth. This was apparent to Mrs. Crawford, chairman of the Guild's Reorganization Committee.

"The attempt to operate the Little Theatre without a guaranteed income, which was successful for the first ten years, has resulted for the last five years in massive deficits, which make it impossible to continue on the same basis," Mrs. Crawford wrote.

In 1934, members of the executive committee, including Guild President William L. Phelps, Yale professor Jack Crawford, treasurer Harold Welch, and Mrs. Winthrop G. Bushnell, announced that the Little Theatre on Lincoln was going broke. The 1929 Great Depression was largely to blame: it forced most of the part-time Guild thespians to seek full-time jobs to put food on the table. Membership dropped, and so did members' ability to pay dues. The Lincoln Theatre was losing about 4,000 dollars annually, which wasn't an amount of money to take lightly in the 1930s—approximately 75,000 dollars by today's standards. The theater tried enforcing dues on its dwindling membership, but the money just wasn't there. No one had much of anything to contribute. In 1936, the Little Theatre, stripped of its former glory, was forced to close its doors.

Dilapidated and all but abandoned, the theater effectively disappeared from the public record until 1943, three years after the breakout of the Second World War. As

the economy rebounded under the New Deal, the windows were stripped of boards, and the doors were reopened to the public. Ownership was transferred to the City of New Haven, and the theater was converted into a single-screen cinema under the Works Projects Act, according to the *New Haven Herald*.

It functioned as a repertory theater for wartime films that briefed the New Haven community on American victories and casualties abroad. Every couple of weeks, citizens of New Haven would pack into the theater and wait for the reel to spin a new account of the American effort to island-hop the Pacific or to fight the Nazis on the Western Front. Until 1945, the theater primarily operated in service of the war, until local actors finally reclaimed the space for occasional performances and films.

The theater had found its niche. For decades, it continued showing films, many made by small independent filmmakers in the U.S. or foreign film companies in postwar Europe. But, as the Little Theater's life stretched into yet another decade, the 1980s, it faced another financial crisis. In 1982, the city had decided to stop supporting the financially-bankrupt theater and created a plan to demolish the building and sell the land to recover the building's growing overhead deficit.

Headlines in local publications reflected a sense of impending loss. *The Register* reported, "Lincoln Flickers and then Shuts." *The Yale Daily News* wrote, "Theater Faces Imminent Demolition." Another article from the *Register,* in October 1982, read like a eulogy for the center: "Lincoln Theatre Flourished Nobly in its Prime." Later, in the November 22, 1982 edition of *The New Yorker*, an article entitled "Lincoln," written by an unnamed Yale alumnus, detailed the Lincoln Theatre's last performance prior to its scheduled demolition later that month. "The theater was as dingy as ever," the article reads, "but what will we do without it?"

Management chose *The Last Picture Show* as the final film to be screened at the theater. It seemed an apt title to conclude the some "hundreds to a thousand" performances that one woman attributed to the theater in an interview for the *East Rock Herald*. On closing night in 1982, one man remembered the first time he visited the theater 30 years prior. "I feel as if I were attending my own funeral," he told *The New Yorker*.

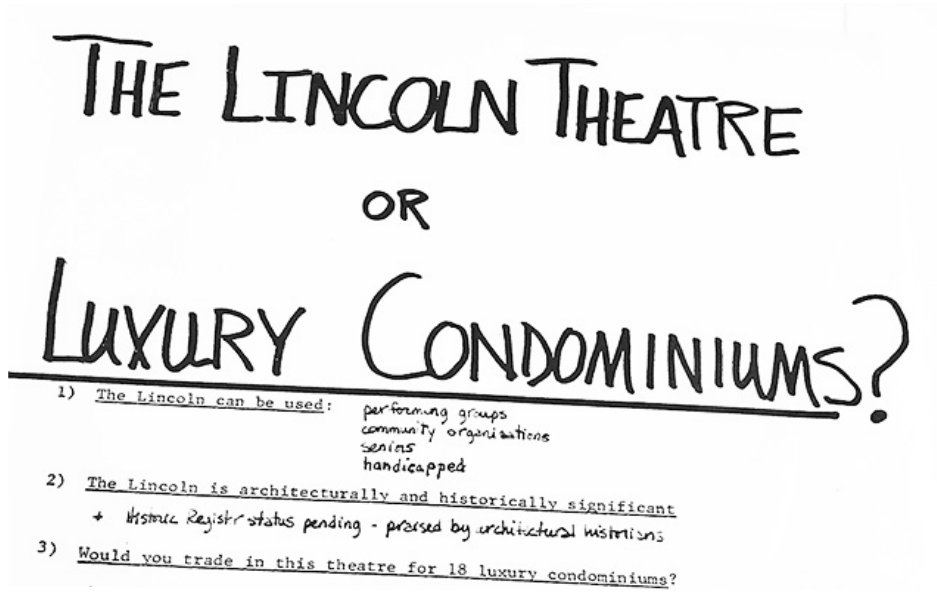
THAT SAME WEEKEND, community members, overwhelmed by emotion as they watched the final show, decided the theater's time had not come yet. They formed a makeshift coalition to prevent, or at least delay, the theater's seemingly imminent demolition.

Nearly 100 community members, patrons, and influential academics recognized the theater's historic value and began sending letters to public officials, going to community meetings, protesting, and posting angry fliers. One of them read, "THE LINCOLN THEATRE OR LUXURY CONDOMINIUMS? THE CHOICE IS YOURS!"

Some hundred people signed petition after petition to nominate the building as a historic landmark.

The Lincoln Committee, as the newfound coalition was called, distributed a monthly paper titled "LINCOLN UPDATE" with vital information for the theater's supporters. In one update from April 1983, the committee announced that the theater was on the brink of destruction. Bulldozers were already lining up at the end of Lincoln Street, staring down the street's dead end at the little theater. But by the next update, the demolition had been delayed. Community members were organizing to research the building's histo-

"...the last of its kind of a movement towards community theater."





ry and petitioning the National Register of Historic Places to ordain it a landmark worthy of protection.

On May 6, 1983, the coalition received a letter from a Mr. John Herzan, a certified "Historic Preservation Consultant." The community had claimed its first major victory.

In his letter, Herzan, who worked for the United States Department of the Interior, detailed all the reasons the Little Theatre on Lincoln Street should be saved. Along with his letter, he submitted a three-inch thick report, including detailed sketches of the theater's architecture, which was endorsed by architectural experts as being wholly unique to the theater and the theater's architect, George H. Gray.

Quite valiantly, the report also stated that the Little Theatre "is, in effect, the last of its kind of a movement towards community theater that included theaters such as the Toy Theatre in Boston, the Little Theatre in New York, the Little Theatre in Chicago, and the remnants of the New York Theatre Guild." The Lincoln Theater was a crucial part of a historic American movement, and Herzan recognized its significance. One playwright testified in the report that "the movement is credited with fostering the talent of such noted American playwrights as Eugene O'Neil, Elmer Rice, George S. Kaufman, Maxwell Anderson, and Robert E. Sherwood."

Over the course of a century, the theater drew immeasurable artistic value not only from its performers but also from its set-builders and costume designers, its volunteers and fundraisers, and its friends and advocates who religiously attended its countless productions. With an army of New Haven community members backing it, no one could lay a finger on the Little Theatre on Lincoln. It was a historic monument, in all of its quaint glory. The Historical Committee, reveling in its victory, handed the theater over to the ACES-ECA Educational Center for the Arts, a private education venture that could more effectively manage the theater's affairs.

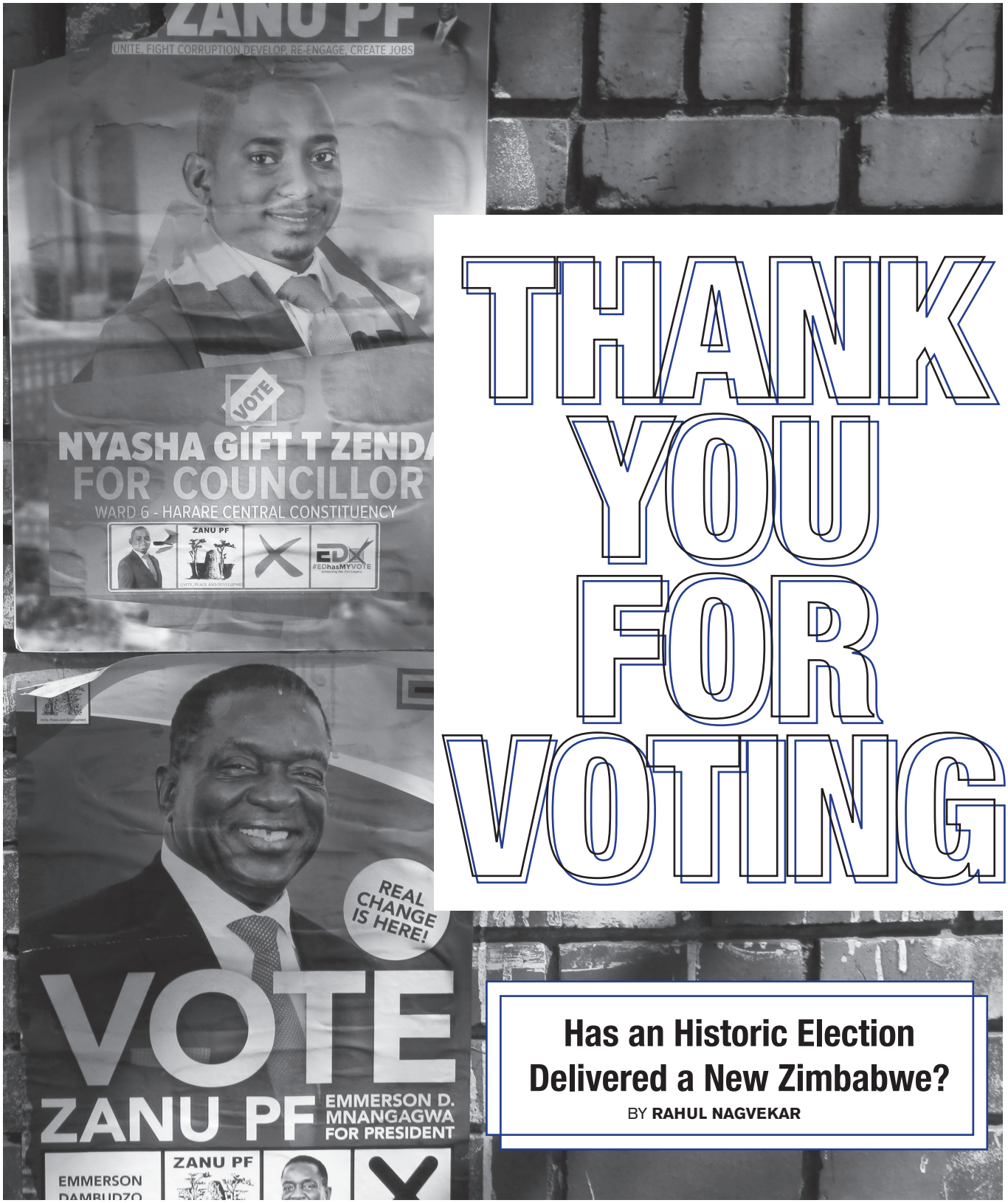
Today, the theater lives off a 9.8 million dollar grant awarded by the Department of the Interior upon the theater's addition to the National Register of Historic Places, a privilege bestowed upon other little American theaters in similar predicaments. The Little Theatre on Lincoln Street is still run and managed by ACES-ECA and is currently open for performances staged by community groups.

In March 1990, *The New York Times* celebrated the theater's salvation: "The Lincoln Theatre, a 65-year-old former playhouse in New Haven, has dodged the wrecker's ball..."

Nearly three decades later, I sat alone in the New Haven Museum. With photos laid out by year across a long table, articles and assorted columns matched with clippings of headlines, and drawings, maps, and sketches of the Little Theatre lined up on the side, I couldn't fathom how the community would have been the same without this place.

"...in the best tradition of melodrama," the *Times* went on, the Little Theatre on Lincoln "has been revived.





THANK YOU FOR VOTING

Has an Historic Election Delivered a New Zimbabwe?

BY **RAHUL NAGVEKAR**

MOTORISTS LEAVING ZIMBABWE'S CAPITAL, Harare, in June and July might have noticed a billboard touting the reelection campaign of incumbent President Emmerson Dambudzo Mnangagwa.

Similar billboards were displayed prominently around Harare, where I was working June through August. The billboards bore slogans like, "Delivering the Zimbabwe You Want," and, "The Voice of the People is the Voice of God." But this one carried a message I was not expecting.

"FOR FREE, FAIR, AND CREDIBLE ELECTIONS," it proclaimed in capital letters. "VOTE EMMERSON D. MNANGAGWA FOR PRESIDENT."

On July 30, 2018, Mnangagwa officially won a fresh five-year term with just under 51 percent of the vote. His main challenger took 44 percent. Alleging massive rigging, Zimbabwe's opposition rejected the result.

In Harare, protests against the suspected rigging turned violent. Rioters destroyed Mnangagwa's billboards and burned buses. The army intervened and killed six people.

Mnangagwa (Zimbabweans call him "E.D.," after his first and middle initials) was first appointed president after a coup last November. The 37-year rule of his predecessor, Robert Mugabe, was notorious for corruption, vote-rigging, and brutal clampdowns on dissent. Mnangagwa wants the world to know that he leads a "new Zimbabwe." A number of the Zimbabweans I met were never convinced.

In some ways, the 2018 vote did mark a change. The months preceding the election were generally peaceful. Observers sent by Western countries to evaluate the vote's fairness—hated by the previous president—were welcomed. Vigorous criticism of Mnangagwa was common in Harare, both in newspapers and on the streets.

Still, in this story, I have changed or omitted some names to protect sources' safety.

In early June, my friend Chipo told me the election would be rigged. "It's the same government that people have been frustrated with for 38 years," she said.

Mnangagwa sought to distance himself from the old regime, promising his "new Zimbabwe." But he had spent decades at Mugabe's side. Both men belonged to the Zimbabwe African National Union-Patriotic Front (ZANU-PF), which has effectively ruled Zimbabwe continuously since independence from Britain in 1980.

Although he denies the allegation, Mnangagwa is widely believed to have directed massacres in the mid-1980s known as Gukurahundi. Genocide scholars estimate that at least 20,000 people died in the massacres, which targeted the Ndebele ethnic minority.

Mnangagwa also played a key role in Mugabe's 2008 reelection. Mugabe won that year's vote after paramilitaries aligned with ZANU-PF killed about 200 opposition supporters. The bloodshed displaced tens of thousands from their homes.

Chipo's adult son, who did not experience the violence firsthand, told me that when the machete-wielding partisans found suspected opposition supporters, they would ask, "Do you want to wear long sleeve or short sleeve?" meaning, "Do you want us to cut at the wrist or at the elbow?"

Another friend, Lan, was frustrated that some Zimbabweans were willing to overlook Mnangagwa's troubled past.

"I hear people going around saying, '*E.D. pfee! E.D. pfee!*'" he told me a few weeks before the 2018 election. The phrase, a rallying cry among Mnangagwa's supporters, means "E.D.



Parts of Harare's Central Business District were affected by post-election violence.

PHOTOS BY **RAHUL NAGVEKAR**

“You don’t stage a coup just to give up power through elections a few months later.”

in!” in Shona, Zimbabwe’s most widely spoken language.

“How can people forget?” Lan asked. “This is the same E.D. who convinced Robert Mugabe to stay in power, and now he is calling himself an angel.”

Tens of thousands took to Harare’s streets to celebrate the 2017 coup—engineered by Mugabe’s detractors in ZANU-PF and the army—that brought Mnangagwa into office. But the marchers were mostly opposition supporters glad to see Mugabe go. Few believed that their new president was a committed democrat.

“You don’t stage a coup just to give up power through elections a few months later,” Chipo told me repeatedly.

Since she predicted rigging, Chipo did not vote. “There’s no point in voting in an election in which I already know the result,” she reasoned.

Lan also expected irregularities, but he was more optimistic.

“E.D. will rig, and he will still lose,” Lan predicted confidently the week before the vote. Lan was backing Nelson Chamisa, Zimbabwe’s main opposition leader, and his Movement for Democratic Change (MDC) Alliance.

Lan took part in Chamisa’s closing rally in Harare, and he estimated it drew 50,000 attendees. Chamisa enjoyed strong support from Zimbabwe’s youth, many of whom lack formal jobs. In Harare, many have turned to hawking fruits and clothes. Some who have cars use their vehicles as unlicensed taxis.

In late June, I met a group of these taxi drivers on a potholed Harare street. In a fair election, one driver told me, “Chamisa will get 98 percent, maybe 100 percent. Because all of Zimbabwe, we are tired of this fucking shit.”

Chamisa was confident he could fix the economy. At a rally in January, he claimed he had met with President Donald Trump. According to Chamisa, Trump agreed to give 15 billion dollars to Zimbabwe on the condition of an MDC victory. There was one problem: the meeting never happened.

This was one of multiple outlandish things Chamisa told his supporters. He promised that if he became president, the Olympics and the FIFA World Cup would be held in Zimbabwe. He also proposed a Zimbabwean bullet train that he said would travel at 600 kilometers per hour, or 373 miles per hour—faster than all known commercial trains.

Lan appreciated the vision behind the bold plans. “People can say whatever they want about Chamisa. I like that man,” Lan told me. “He represents hope. Hope that we didn’t have under Robert Mugabe.”

Mnangagwa also tried to sell hope. During his campaign, he repeated the slogan, “Zimbabwe is open for business.” He ran feel-good YouTube ads promising a new dawn for the country. Posters his supporters put up on Harare’s walls and trees announced, “Real change is here!”

Rural voters were getting a distinct flavor of ZANU-PF campaigning. According to Chipo, chiefs close to ZANU-PF threatened to withhold food aid from subjects who supported the opposition. (Foreign and domestic election observers also noted intimidation.)

But Mnangagwa does enjoy genuine popularity in Zimbabwe. When he promised to lead the nation to a brighter future, millions took him at his word.

This troubled Lan to no end. “You come home, there’s no [food] to eat,” he told me as we passed a crowd of ZANU-PF supporters returning from a rally. “And you’re saying, ‘*E.D. pfee, E.D. pfee*?’”

Chamisa struggled to convince many disillusioned voters. Some were concerned by his apparently close relationship with a bitter Mugabe, who effectively endorsed Chamisa on the eve of the election.

“I know I don’t want E.D. to win. I don’t know who I want to win,” my friend Gugulethu told me in early July.

She did not trust Chamisa. His alleged business partnerships with Mugabe-owned dairy farms worried her, and she thought he was a liar and a hothead.

“If he loses, he’ll tell his people to go march on State House,” Gugulethu said of Chamisa. Then, she predicted, the army would be called in. “And that will be the end.”

Lan approved of Chamisa’s aggressive tack, and he saw an alliance with Mugabe as a smart strategic move.

People were voting to put food on the table, Lan told me.

He saw the election as a simple choice: accept five more years like the previous 38, or take a chance on the unknown, and hope for the best.

Gugulethu, who ended up voting reluctantly for Chamisa, agreed. When the economy was better, she told me, she had decided against emigrating to the U.S. Since then, she had seen her salary diminish and the cost of living increase. Zimbabwe's leaders had only become richer.

"That's why I'm voting," she said. "I'm voting for change. To get these crooks out."

More than four million Zimbabweans turned out to vote on Monday, July 30. International media covered the long lines at polling stations for the historic election. It was the first in Zimbabwe without Robert Mugabe as a candidate.

After the polls closed at 7 p.m., Zimbabwe Electoral Commission (ZEC) officials began tallying votes at each polling station. Preliminary results trickled in throughout the night. Before dawn on Tuesday, Chamisa tweeted that he had seen most of the returns and declared victory.

Lan did not celebrate. Unconfirmed social media reports suggested that Mnangagwa was racking up huge margins in rural areas.

Wild stories began to circulate: polling stations kept open until 4 a.m., allegedly so that ZANU-PF could round up and threaten non-voters, and ballot boxes transported to be stuffed with pre-ticked papers.

By Wednesday afternoon, ZEC had not released any official presidential results. MDC supporters on Harare's streets, suspecting rigging, were losing patience.



A Mnangagwa banner covering a face of ZANU-PF's headquarters reads: "THE VOICE OF THE PEOPLE IS THE VOICE OF GOD."



Newspapers for sale at a Harare street corner weigh in on post-election developments.

"We want Chamisa," some of them chanted. They began to throw stones, deface posters, and burn cars and buses.

Within hours, the army arrived to establish order. "I'll show you free and fair!" one soldier shouted at protesters, according to a foreign correspondent.

The troops shot six people dead. None of the victims carried guns; at least two were not part of the riots. Ishmael Kumire was a vendor who, according to relatives, refused to abandon his tomatoes for fear they would be looted. Sylvia Maphosa, an employee of Zimbabwe's water agency, was shot in the back as she left her workplace.

One video showed a soldier firing indiscriminately until a superior stopped him. Another video emerged of a soldier stopping a minibus, ordering its driver to the ground, and beating him.

"This country is a circus," Lan told me later. "Where is the justice?"

On Thursday, police raided MDC's headquarters. Mnangagwa's win was announced that night.

MDC alleged that at least hundreds of thousands of votes were fraudulent. But after Wednesday's shootings, no one risked demonstrating.

On Thursday and Friday evenings, soldiers entered bars and shops in MDC strongholds around Harare to beat civilians. Outside the capital, opposition activists were abducted and raped. Chipo told me some frustrated youth talked of civil war.

"We need to pray," Chipo said. "Because this country is headed for disaster."

Chamisa challenged the election result in Zimbabwe's Constitutional Court; again, he lost. The court upheld Mnangagwa's victory on Friday, August 24. The president was sworn in two days later.

Chamisa and his supporters claimed that anomalies in ZEC's figures were proof of fraud. In one constituency, four pairs of polling stations showed identical official results for all 23 presidential candidates, according to public data.

ZEC admitted that it gave Mnangagwa about 4,000 extra votes due to "observed errors," while maintaining that the mistakes did not affect the election outcome. Initially, Mnangagwa had cleared the 50-percent-plus-one-vote threshold—required to avoid a runoff—by fewer than 40,000 votes.

In recent weeks, Zimbabwe's economic situation has worsened. A cash shortage has led to skyrocketing prices, long lines for fuel, and empty shelves.

"Cooking oil!" Lan told me with astonishment over the phone in October as he named products that had disappeared from most stores. Basic medicines were also on the list.

In October, European Union observers released their final report on the election. The observers acknowledged the competitive and "largely peaceful" election environment.

But they expressed concerns over voter intimidation, ZEC's appearance of bias, and the post-poll deaths in Harare—some of the many aspects of the election that, according to the report, "failed to meet international standards."

Lan believes Zimbabwe's economic prospects are bleak. He would like to leave the country, at least temporarily. But Chipo, who has lived in Zimbabwe through part of the colonial era and all of Mugabe's rule, is staying put.

She told me, "I have learned to make lemonade from the given lemons."

"We need to pray," Chipo said. "Because this country is headed for disaster."

#METOO



in Movement

Breaking the Silence of the Ballet

BY **SARAH MARSLAND**





I WAS SIX YEARS OLD the first time I heard it.

"No talking," said the ballet mistress. "Ballet is a silent art."

It was the first of many phrases that ballet would drill into my mind over the course of 13 years. In reality, ballet is an art form full of language. My ballet teachers often spoke in their own predictable yet highly specific aphorisms. Over time, I was able to anticipate their corrections—*heels forward, shoulders down*—sometimes even before they said a word out loud. I could hear the phrases in my head and would adjust my body accordingly, so that when my teacher did walk by, I would instead be given a new correction to chew on.

"Ballet is a silent art," however, was a saying of a different breed. It was my introduction to that other part of ballet—the part that regulates not just your dancing but your behavior inside, and often outside, the studio. Just a first-grader, I was being trained in this system of ballet etiquette, which teaches dancers to be silent, obedient, and pleasant under all circumstances.

There are rules in the ballet studio. For a young person, these laws are deeply ingrained. No leaning on the barre. Never cross your arms; it makes you look angry and thus disrespectful of authority.

Always keep a pleasant expression on your face. Always curtsy at the end of class. Never argue with the teacher, but thank her for any correction you receive. Make your appearance impeccably neat; never come to class with messy hair or the wrong leotard. And always, always tuck your ribbons in. Sew them if you must. Nothing is tackier than a ballerina with her pointe shoe ribbons showing.

This whole demographic of women who, professionally or pre-professionally, have had their identity and agency chipped away, now stands vulnerable to further violations of their autonomy and self-worth.

Are all of these rules necessary? It's hard to say. Perhaps some more than others. All I know is that striving to live by them often made the ballet studio a puritanical place.

We all knew the experience of being shamed in front of our peers or of watching it happen to someone else. It was a feeling we'd do anything to avoid. As a result, most of us obeyed. Those who didn't tended to be the girls who fell out of favor with the teachers or stopped coming to class entirely. They were often the girls whose bodies didn't fit the ballet "type," threatening the supposed sanctity of that virginal, waif-like image we were all supposed to embody.

Sex is an unspoken but ever-present entity in the studio. Physical development is feared, as it distorts the body into something softer, more vulgar, and much harder to control.



PHOTOS VIA **KATHRYN WIRSING**

Natalie Portman spoke about this in an interview describing her preparation for her role in Darren Aronofsky's psychological thriller, *Black Swan*: "[Ballet] is really a world that keeps women as little girls."

Portman noticed that many of the dancers she consulted in preparation for the role still spoke like young girls. She used this "baby voice" when she played Nina, a ballet dancer performing the lead role in the iconic ballet, *Swan Lake*. The ballet tells the story of a girl who is transformed into a swan by an evil sorcerer; the ballerina must learn to embody both the vulnerability of the white swan and the manipulative seduction of the black swan.

Portman's character and her experiences are no fictional creation. Plenty of former dancers have criticized the hierarchical structure of ballet from outside the walls of the theater. Yet current dancers have remained almost unequivocally silent.

In my own experience, it's often the girls who "made it" that deny the realities of those who didn't. This isn't because they're inherently spiteful, or ruthless, or mean. Dancers don't believe other dancers when they speak up about their struggles because they are grateful for their success, and in the ballet world, this gratitude is expressed through undying loyalty to the art.

Vanessa Carlton, a former student at the School of American Ballet, told me she saw this gratitude and loyalty firsthand in her teachers, many of whom were themselves former dancers with the New York City Ballet, the company founded alongside the school. The instructors often perpetuated the same dynamics that they had experienced when they were younger. "Victims and enablers can be the same people," Carlton said.

"The part that was extremely disturbing to me was witnessing one of the head teachers verbally call out and embarrass some of the girls in my class," Carlton recalled. "There was one girl in my class who she fixated on. Every single class she would stop and berate this girl. The girl was working her ass off. … I stood in that class and watched it and my blood boiled."

For some students, the anger of witnessing these public humiliations can begin to outweigh the satisfaction and joy of dance as a potential career. For others, that anger gets dissolved, absorbed, and suppressed for fear of losing their chances as a result of speaking up—that is, until silence is no longer an option.

When Peter Martins retired from his position as ballet master in chief of New York City Ballet in January, after facing allegations of verbal and physical abuse from five dancers, the ballet world seemed to tremble like a studio floor under the weight of twenty pointe shoe-clad women.

It was a shock, to say the least. Martins, who had led the company since the 1983 death of founder George Balanchine, had long been hailed as the unofficial leader of American ballet. His retirement left City Ballet scrambling to find a replacement.

As a student at the School from 1994 to 1998, Carlton's personal experience with Martins was limited. On the occasions that he did teach class, however, she remembers a heightened feeling of intimidation and an eagerness to please.

"You're kind of brainwashed into thinking that Martins is king," Carlton said. Recalling her experience as a student in his class, she said, "He put his hand—he has these big hands—and he just kind of led dancers around at times by the backs of their heads. I guarantee you, not one dancer—because their job is in jeopardy—could ever say to him, 'That makes me uncomfortable. Please don't do that.'"

It was this stark imbalance of power which alarmed Carlton the most as a young dancer aspiring to join the company.

At its worst, this culture of silence can serve to maintain an environment of outright violence and exploitation, as in the case of Alexandra Waterbury, a former student at the School of American Ballet. In August, Waterbury came forward with allegations of sexual harassment and abuse against multiple New York City Ballet male principal dancers and is now suing both the individual dancers and City Ballet for creating what she calls a "fraternity house environment...

Consider this my call from the audience to her. I dare her to do it.

I dare her to speak.

that emboldens [male members of the Company] to disregard the law and violate the basic rights of women."

The lawsuit accuses Chase Finlay, a principal dancer who has since left the company, of taking and sharing explicit photos and videos of Waterbury with other male dancers and company donors. Finlay and the other dancers exchanged lewd and demeaning comments about Waterbury and other female dancers, many of whom were students at the time. In one text message conversation cited in the suit, New York City Ballet donor Jared Longhitano suggests to Finlay that "we could tie some of [the female dancers] up and abuse them like farm animals"—to which Finlay added, "or like the sluts they are."

Emily Coates, director of the dance studies curriculum at Yale University and a former dancer with New York City Ballet, wrote in an email to me that the company culture at City Ballet "promoted a kind of obedience to authority." She added, "I had the feeling while in the company that using my voice, having an opinion, and thinking critically were perceived to be somehow un-ballerina-like."

I have often wondered if the emotion we witness when we watch a ballerina perform is simply an expression of the pain which accumulates from years of being taught to endure at all costs. In every one of my friends who grew up dancing, I can recognize a hint of that dying swan, a deep yearning for freedom after years of being confined to a form which was not authentically theirs.

Perhaps that is why ballet is so beautiful to watch. To me, the best performances were always the ones that felt like small acts of resistance—little earthquakes, silent to the audience, that under the floorboards of the stage rumbled loudly.

But does the ability to express oneself on stage constitute freedom in a practical sense? What good is artistic expression if it doesn't provide one with a voice to stand up for herself when she is harassed, abused, and exploited offstage?

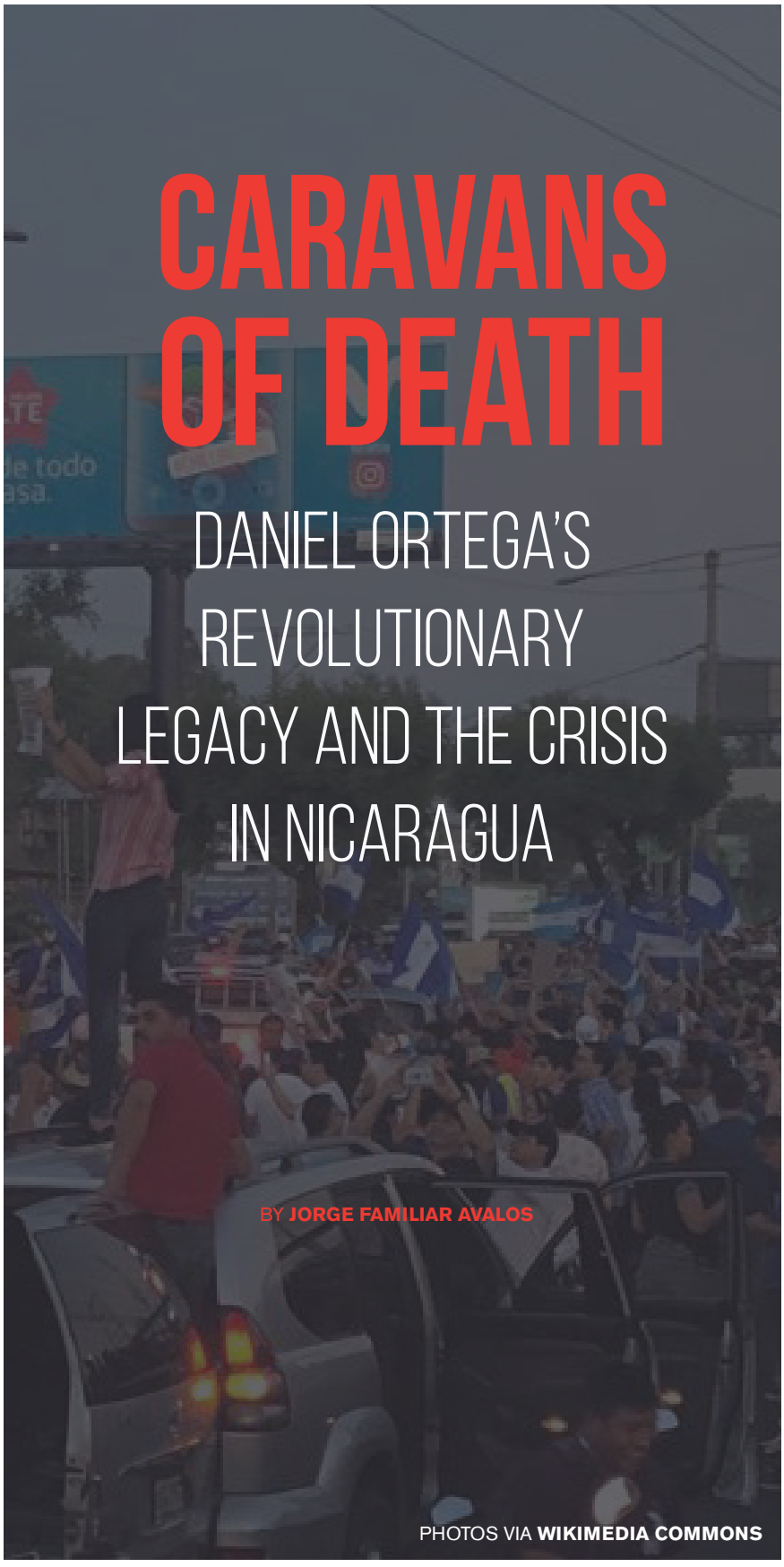
"I had the feeling while in the company that using my voice, having an opinion, and thinking critically were perceived to be somehow un-ballerina-like."



Dance is a powerful tool of communication, but that does not make up for the ways in which dancers are systematically kept quiet when it comes to concerns about their safety and wellbeing. This culture of suppression creates a population of female dancers who emerge from the ballet world (or stay in it as teachers and, on rare occasions, directors) with a code of silence ingrained in their bodies and minds. This whole demographic of women who, professionally or pre-professionally, have had their identity and agency chipped away, now stands vulnerable to further violations of their autonomy and self-worth.

I do not consider it a coincidence that I spent my first years following my exit from the ballet in the throes of an emotionally abusive relationship with a person who kept me perpetually silent, apologetic, and eager to please. These are qualities that society encourages in women and that ballet serves to enforce, perhaps more harshly than any other art form.

I can only hope that dancers like Waterbury represent the beginning of an avalanche of voices highlighting the changes necessary to make ballet safe for women. It is time that we stop silencing ourselves for the sake of this beautiful art, stop pretending that abuse is necessary to produce great work, and face the truth that perhaps the swan queen was never really a swan at all. Perhaps she was just a woman in a costume, deceived by a man into believing she had no voice—a woman who shouldn't need to suffer in order to be heard. She is dancing tonight in a yellow spotlight, in a theater in a city in a country in a world. She has thought so many times of it, the blasphemy of breaking that sacred wall of silence. Consider this my call from the audience to her. I dare her to do it. I dare her to speak.



CARAVANS OF DEATH

DANIEL ORTEGA'S REVOLUTIONARY LEGACY AND THE CRISIS IN NICARAGUA

BY **JORGE FAMILIAR AVALOS**

PHOTOS VIA **WIKIMEDIA COMMONS**

DAY AND NIGHT, groups of heavily armed men patrol the streets of León, Nicaragua. Police officers and paramilitaries travel in what locals call "caravans of death." Sometimes they ride in cruisers with the official logos of the national police force. Other times they opt for beat-up pickup trucks without license plates or any other form of identification. The caravans have been active since late June, when the Nicaraguan government deployed them under the *plan limpieza*, or the cleanup operation. Besides making their daily rounds to intimidate León's residents, the brigades arrest protesters, disperse crowds, and kidnap particularly notorious dissidents.

The caravans are far from the only state mechanism working against the opposition. The courts have sentenced many protesters to decades in prison for alleged crimes and links to terrorism.

The city of León is not unique. "All of Nicaragua is living under a state of fear," Erendira Vanegas, a León resident and project coordinator with the New Haven-León Sister City Project, told *The Politic*. Since April, President Daniel Ortega's leftist administration has cracked down on protesters across the country.

The protests originally challenged an unpopular pension reform plan. While the administration quickly discarded the reform, the movement continued, demanding democratic change and giving voice to a long list of grievances against Ortega's government. Ortega has insisted that he wants to bring peace to Nicaragua, but his implicit endorsement of violent repression overshadows his one-time legacy as Nicaragua's revolutionary liberator.

ORTEGA PRESIDED OVER MORE than a decade of economic stability beginning in 2006, earning him public confidence. According to the International Monetary Fund, Nicaragua's GDP grew an impressive 4.9 percent in 2017 alone under Ortega's presidency.

Nicaraguans and international observers alike widely regarded his administration as a capable manager of the economy.

And at pro-government rallies in the nation's capital, Managua, it appears as if public sentiment has not changed. Thousands gather every few weeks in the city's famous squares to hear Ortega boast about the social aid programs that have been a cornerstone of his political success and his popularity as the leader of the Sandinista National Liberation Front (FSLN). Sandinista and Nicaraguan flags wave in the air as the throngs roar their approval.

In recent months, Ortega has used these speeches to decry "terrorists" participating in what he claims is an American-orchestrated coup against him.

Despite the president's rhetoric, hundreds of thousands of Nicaraguans have expressed their discontent with Ortega in streets throughout the country. The crowds have grown steadily since April 16, when Ortega and his government first announced reforms to the country's pension system.

In February, the International Monetary Fund recommended raising the retirement age to address a growing deficit, but the government instead chose to increase contribution rates while decreasing pensions by five percent.

Angry pensioners and university students marched in Managua and León on April 18, when the reforms were formally implemented by presidential decree.

The protests were peaceful, but the government's reaction was not. In both cities, riot police and pro-government groups like the Sandinista Youth, a paramilitary organization that has supported Ortega throughout his political career, attacked the protesters. As the police fired rubber bullets and sprayed tear gas, the paramilitaries assaulted demonstrators with clubs.

Over the next few days, hundreds of thousands of Nicaraguans took to the streets to denounce the violence, only to be met with more of it. This time, the police fired real bullets into the crowds, and the paramilitaries replaced their clubs with firearms.

Ortega withdrew the reforms on April 22 in response to the protesters' initial complaints. By then, 30 people were already dead. In the crisis that has gripped the country for the last seven months, over 300 people have lost their lives, according to the Inter-American Commission on Human Rights (IACHR). Pensions are no longer the main issue. Now, protesters are denouncing authoritarianism.

ORTEGA, WHO HAD HELPED BRING **DEMOCRACY** TO NICARAGUA, WOULD FROM THEN ON WORK TO **SUBVERT** IT.

DANIEL ORTEGA FIRST CAME to power in the summer of 1979, when a popular revolution led by the FSLN deposed the dictator Anastasio Somoza Debayle, the third and final ruler in a family dynasty that had controlled Nicaragua for 43 years.

"The first two Somozas did not represent the worst aspects of *c*," Gilbert Joseph, Farnam Professor of History and International Studies at Yale University, told *The Politic*. "Anastasio Somoza Debayle treated the state much more like a personal fief, and he used the National Guard as his regime's strongmen."

In the late 1970s, facing a credible threat from the Sandinista rebels, the Somoza regime cracked down on the opposition. Critics were arbitrarily jailed and tortured. The National Guard used brutal, even fatal, force to disperse crowds and targeted key opposition figures for assassination.

Ortega, then a guerrilla leader, was captured and tortured during his time in prison. His hard-won reputation for toughness and unquestionable commitment to the anti-Somoza cause allowed him to rise to the top of a crowded field of Sandinista leaders at the end of the revolution.

A prisoner swap released Ortega in time for the Sandinistas' victory, and he became a prominent figure in the new Nicaraguan government during its conflict with the contras, a right-wing guerrilla group backed by the United States. He was chosen as the Sandinistas' candidate in Nicaragua's first post-revolution presidential election in 1984, and he won. Ortega ran again in 1990 but was dealt a shocking defeat by Violeta Chamorro and her center-right National Opposition Union (UNO). Nicaraguans were ready for change after more than a decade of Sandinista rule.

"The Sandinistas did what seemed to be a noble thing and respected the elections after losing in a surprising but clear result," Joseph commented.

According to Vanegas, the electoral loss was an inflection point in Ortega's relationship with democracy. "Everyone thought that the Sandinistas and Ortega were going to stay in power, but in 1990 Ortega loses the election," she said. "He never let go of power, and he made many pacts with the governments that arrived."

Ortega, who had helped bring democracy to Nicaragua, would from then on work to subvert it.

Following the 1990 loss, the Sandinistas began organizing riots to challenge the democratically-elected governments that succeeded theirs, drawing on Ortega's popularity to build support. The approach led many progressive Sandinista leaders to leave the party, allowing Ortega to consolidate his grip. Meanwhile, he kept run-

ning for president and losing.

After Ortega lost to Arnoldo Alemán of the Constitutionalist Liberal Party in the 1996 election, the two made a deal to split control of many of Nicaragua's institutions between their respective parties.

"The two pacted to protect their roles as *caudillos* [authoritarian political leaders]," said Joseph. Most importantly, the pact allowed Ortega to retain his political relevance. He returned to the presidency in 2006 despite securing less than 40 percent of the vote, with new electoral laws permitting presidential victories by plurality.

Álvaro Leiva, the executive secretary of the Nicaraguan Pro-Human Rights Association (ANPDH), characterized the period that followed as the origin of today's crisis. "The social problems related to the violation of human rights, injustice, impunity, and indolence have been developing since Ortega returned to power a little over ten years ago," Leiva said in a phone interview with *The Politic*.

Since 2006, Ortega has taken steps to centralize power with the support of his party. Ortega ran and won again in 2011 and 2016 after a constitutional amendment abolished presidential term limits. He approved a new security law, appointing himself the national police force's supreme commander. Along the way, Ortega hardened his stance on protesters and has increasingly used incarceration and violence to silence dissent.

"People have become frustrated by an increasing lack of transparency," Kevin Amaya, a research associate at the Washington Office on Latin America, told *The Politic*. "For a while now, President Ortega has been undermining Nicaraguan institutions to consolidate his power over them."



A woman stands near a burning barricade, lifting the national flag of Nicaragua during a 2018 protest against President Ortega's social security reforms.
PHOTO VIA **VOICES OF AMERICA**

ON APRIL 24, after six days of protests, the government agreed to hold peace talks with the Civic Alliance for Justice and Democracy, a group of civil society and religious leaders who would negotiate on behalf of the protest movement.

Despite this announcement, neither the crowds nor the police desisted. The negotiations only resulted in a 48-hour truce that had no substantive effects, as the government refused to admit that its violent suppression of the protests had been a mistake.

On May 30, Nicaragua's Mother's Day, marches attended by hundreds of thousands of people were held to honor the mothers of protesters who had been killed or arrested. Again, the government doubled down. Police snipers forced their way onto residential rooftops and fired into the crowds. Paramilitaries came in truckloads, wielding assault rifles. By the end of the day, 16 more protesters were dead and nearly 200 injured.

According to Fernanda, a college student from Managua who has since left the country, Mother's Day marked a new low. She participated in some of the movement's very first marches and took to the streets with her entire family that day.

Fernanda, whose real name is not being used for her safety, did not witness any of the violence firsthand, but her grandfather's car was set on fire by paramilitaries. She knew that she was lucky to have made it back home. In Nicaragua, speaking out against the government is now a matter of life and death.

"My friends and I have stayed away from the marches since then," Fernanda told *The Politic*. "The risk of violence that anyone who protests faces is really terrifying." Even in the earliest days of the crisis, Fernanda was forced to leave home at dawn to avoid running into paramilitaries on her way to school. And in mid-May, the last two months of classes were abruptly canceled.

Around the same time, the local supermarket ran low on food and water as people hysterically built stockpiles. Many of Fernanda's friends changed their names on Facebook when news spread that pro-government forces were monitoring social media and kidnapping vocal critics. To this day, Fernanda's family does not leave home after 4:30 p.m.

As mass protests became too dangerous, Nicaragua's university students adopted a new strategy: blocking the nation's main highways. When the government used brute force to break the roadblocks, the students decided to raise barricades neighborhood by neighborhood, closing city streets throughout the country.

This approach—which the Sandinistas had themselves used in the 1970s to put pressure on Somoza—was meant to wage economic warfare against the government. Its scale ensured its suc-

cess: Vanegas insists there were more barricades in León last June than at the time of the Sandinista Revolution. Businesses closed, schools were suspended, and trash collectors gave up on their jobs as roads became inaccessible. The economic growth for which Ortega was once lauded vanished, with GDP projected to shrink by six percent this year.

The government has been using this economic standstill to justify the *plan limpieza*. According to Vanegas, the government argued that the "cleanup plan" was just meant to collect garbage that had accumulated grotesquely. But instead of trash collectors, violent "caravans of death" swept through the streets.

The *plan limpieza* brought about frequent skirmishes between protesters defending the barricades with rocks and mortars made of scrap metal and heavily-armed police officers trying to tear them down. On the plan's first day, three teenagers were killed by police in Vanegas' neighborhood. One of them, just 18 years old, was top of his class at the local law school.

"The government is cruelly torturing and killing those who are the future of Nicaragua," Vanegas said.

Vanegas, an active participant in the protest movement, could no longer make the trip from her home to her office in León. She spent two months unable to travel to the rural communities where she manages workshops on domestic violence prevention. Instead, her organization found new ways to support those in need. It decided to assist the university students, the leaders of the protest movement. Many of them have moved permanently onto their campuses, which serve as the movement's operational bases. Because of the risk of arrest, returning home is no longer an option.

Vanegas' organization brought the students food and medicine, a necessary provision, given that public hospitals have refused to serve protesters since the movement began. The government explicitly ordered doctors to call the police if injured protesters checked in. In some cases, including in León, protesters have been arrested or kidnapped at hospitals.

Seeking medical attention has become a death sentence for the government's critics.

EXTRAJUDICIAL KILLINGS and politically-motivated imprisonments are part and parcel of the government's repression. Nicaraguan civil society groups have kept arduous records of the carnage—the ANPDH reported on October 20 that the death toll had reached 528 and found that 4,100 people had been injured and another 1,609 kidnapped by pro-government forces.

From Managua alone, several horrific stories have attracted international attention. On June 17, the day after the National Dialogue, six members of a family died in an arson attack on their house. Six days later, a one-year-old boy was shot and killed by a police officer.

On July 12, pro-government forces broke through the barricades at the National Autonomous University of Nicaragua. Around 100 students sought refuge in the nearby Church of Jesus of the Divine Mercy. The police and paramilitaries attacked the church, leaving two dead and 16 injured.

An average of 200 Nicaraguans apply for asylum in neighboring Costa Rica every day, with entire families embracing the uncertainty of moving to a new country in order to escape the violence that has consumed their homeland, according to an August 18 report from the United Nations Human Rights Office of the High Commissioner (OHCHR). The report also claims that of thousands of protesters arrested, at least 300 have been prosecuted and charged, and at least 85 faced terrorism-related charges. On August 31, Ortega ordered the expulsion of UN human rights observers from Nicaragua.

Some of Ortega's most prominent critics have also left Nicaragua to escape persecution. Carlos Mejía Godoy, a Nicaraguan singer who contributed to the campaign against Somoza in the 1970s and has since be-



Protesters participating in the 2018 demonstration against President Ortega's social security reforms hold a candlelight vigil in respect to those killed. It is rumored that the government is currently torturing captured demonstrators.

come one of Ortega's most vocal critics, announced that he had left for Costa Rica on August 3. The next day, Leiva himself fled to Costa Rica.

"We have come under a siege, a repression, and a persecution for our humanitarian work," Leiva told The Politic. "The government has tried to delegitimize us and we have become victims of the criminalization of our work as defenders of human rights." The ANPDH indefinitely closed its offices throughout Nicaragua the day he left the country.

Young Nicaraguans have been condemned to decades in prison for their participation in the protest movement. They are being accused of partaking in a plot to overthrow the government or of committing crimes despite little or no evidence against them. Ortega has fully embraced this narrative, frequently referring to protesters as "coup-mongers" acting as part of a "Yankee conspiracy" in speeches and interviews.

"We have an administration that is governing the country under pain, bloodshed, impunity, injustice, and the violation of human rights," said Leiva. "The government is blind, deaf, and mute when it comes to the fundamental rights of life and citizenship."

UNSURPRISINGLY, THE government's response to the protest movement has hurt Ortega's popularity and brought anger about his consolidation of power into the mainstream.

"On the street people say that Ortega and Somoza are the same thing," Vanegas commented. "The image of Daniel Ortega as a liberator and revolutionary, if it ever existed, has been sent to the dustbin of history. What is happening now is not a new thing, for many people this was already a regime and we already called it a murderous dictatorship."

Joseph thinks it is possible that Ortega was always more power-hungry than committed to democracy.

"Lately he's morphed into a figure much like that of Maduro in Venezuela, the worst kind of autocrat who, along with Rosario Murillo, his wife and vice president, has created an *orteguismo* that is very reminiscent of *somocismo*," he said.

FEAR HAS BEATEN THE NICARAGUAN PEOPLE INTO A BRUTALLY ENFORCED **COMPLACENCY**.

But even as Ortega's status as a quasi-dictatorial autocrat has gained mainstream acceptance, the opposition still lacks a defined endgame. They agree that Ortega has to go, but how, or even if, this will happen remains unclear. Even as many former members of Ortega's base have stopped supporting him, protests are becoming smaller and less frequent.

"The crisis has been normalized," Fernanda said. Fear has beaten the Nicaraguan people into a brutally enforced complacency. Protesting is accurately seen as an extremely dangerous endeavor.

By late August, school resumed, and many businesses reopened. Today, the government continues to track down and arrest, often in home invasions, those who have marched or posted online in support of the opposition movement.

Leiva still believes that the crisis can be resolved, but only if the international community does its part. "We need international pressure that can lead the regime and Ortega to see the possibility of handing over power," he said.

But Ortega adamantly refuses to resign or to hold elections before the 2021 presidential race, arguing that doing so would hurt Nicaragua's democracy. Since the crisis began, he has repeatedly stated that restoring peace in Nicaragua is his priority. "Without peace it is not possible to achieve greater advances in the social, economic, and political order," he told Andrés Oppenheimer in a CNN interview on July 31.

And yet, Vanegas remains hopeful. "Championing the struggle peacefully has given us a lot of hope and encouraged us to continue to demand justice," she said. "The government also says it wants peace but continues to repress and incarcerate innocent people. We are working for peace, but we also want justice for all of the victims."

ACTIVIST, FRIEND, COMRADE

Interview with Patrisse Cullors, Co-Founder of Black Lives Matter

BY **TRENT KANNEGIETER**

PATRISSE CULLORS IS an activist, author, and playwright from Los Angeles, California. She is best known as one of the co-founders of the Black Lives Matter movement, and she advocates for human rights issues such as prison abolition. Her most recent book, *When They Call You a Terrorist: A Black Lives Matter Memoir*, was published in January 2018.

***The Politic*: I wanted to start by asking you about a few of your formative moments, as your activism started pretty early on. I was wondering specifically what lessons you learned working with the Bus Riders Union as a teen growing up in Southern California.**

Cullors: I love that. … Nobody ever asks me about the Bus Riders Union.

The Bus Riders Union was my first political home. It's a place that trained me to be the organizer I am today. I started as a member at 17 and a half and stayed there for 11 years. It was incredibly formative; I was given a lot of room and space to grow as a leader in the organization and to develop other leaders of the organization. It taught me the very premise of organizing, which is not about building your own personal brand, but about building the team. And that has been incredibly important.

In the same vein of formative experiences, religion has played a large role in your life. I was wondering if you could tell us about how you started to bring Ifá into your life and how you made the decision to bring its rituals to your rallies?

I actually started to study Ifá, maybe…in my early twenties? And I felt really connected to the tradition. One, because it comes from Nigeria—from the Yoruba people in particular—and I felt incredibly connected to West Africa. I think the other part was that it was really practical. I come from a Jehovah's Witness background, which is an incredibly conservative religion and an incredibly conservative experience. I needed a tradition that was more generous to people and to humanity. I needed a tradition that was rooted in African traditions, and so I just naturally started. It's something to know about me: I try to bring my whole self into every experience I have.

"We should not be chasing the trend. What we should be doing is staying focused inside of the work. And being consistent."

So I started to make little ancestor altars in my office when I worked at the Strategy Center, to create a little space of ancestors with little pictures. I thought it was really important to note that we stand on the shoulders of giants in our movement, other civil rights leaders who either were assassinated or died. I think when we started to do chants across the country—that we must love each other, support each other, we have nothing to lose but our chains—I would naturally end it with "Ase," which is like Amen, but in Yoruba. I'm not the one that coined "Ase"; it's from the old language. But it became really popularized in our movement to be present and to be spiritual, and showing that unapologetically.

Can you talk about your experience as a member of the conservative Jehovah's Witnesses and how it affected your liberal values?

Being a Jehovah's Witness very much shaped me and my environment and my friendships, and I think the choice to not continue to be a Jehovah's Witness...was important for me. I couldn't be a Jehovah's Witness and also be queer and also be political. Jehovah's Witnesses are taught not to be in the world. I mean, literally, we are taught not to vote. ... There are hundreds of thousands of witnesses who are eligible to vote but don't because their religion is telling them not to be in the world. This didn't seem practical to me and the life that I live. It felt like it was taking my agency away to be in the world and change the world.

In the past, you've called yourself the wife of Harriet Tubman. What does that mean to you?

I had a very particular moment where I was very obsessed and I was reading everything I could on her: every history book, every children's book, every Google page. I was mapping her, the Underground Railroad tracks she took. I was really going through a moment right before Black Lives Matter where I was wondering what freedom means. I was having a philosophical conversation with myself about freedom, what it takes to be free, out of physical bondage—spiritual, mental, emotional. The one person I could draw from is Harriet, and Harriet would give me more answers. I looked to her and I felt like I became very close and connected to her, and it was sort of like I was married to this ideology she embodied about freedom. ...And so I started to call myself the wife of Harriet Tubman.

I'd like to ask a few questions about social movements in general. If you could isolate a few factors that can make or break a movement, what would you emphasize?

Consistency. Something is always going to be trendy, because we live in a world of social media that makes things trend, literally. We should not be chasing the trend. What we should be doing is staying focused inside of the work. And being consistent. Your work may be trendy or not. I've done plenty of work that didn't become trendy, but it was completely effective and changed the course of history. You have to stay consistent; you have to stay in it—allowing yourself to remain hopeful, even when you don't feel hope. Oftentimes, we think we always do this because we're passionate. If that was the case, then I would not be an organizer because it's not always about passion. Sometimes it's

"Sometimes it's gritty and gruesome, and sometimes it's thankless and confusing. That becomes a really important moment to say, 'I'm here even when I don't feel grateful or hopeful.'"

gritty and gruesome, and sometimes it's thankless and confusing. That becomes a really important moment to say, "I'm here even when I don't feel grateful or hopeful."

Last thing: keep the people you trust closest to you. Keep them close, love up on them, thank them. It's hard to be an activist, and it's even harder to be a friend and comrade or colleagues with activists and organizers because we are at the whims of what is happening politically. And especially in this moment, we are constantly in flux.

In your book that came out this January, you talked about how the shooting of two police officers in Dallas in 2016 was a really pivotal movement for Black Lives Matter, since people started equating the attack with BLM, despite the fact that the shooters dissociated themselves from the movement. How did you go about distancing your movement from this act of violence, and what did managing the crisis teach you about messaging?

It was a really extraordinary and devastating moment. It was devastating as human beings lost their lives, and it was devastating as we were being blamed for it. It was devastating because the protest itself was for black people who lost their lives. I think what we recognized was that we can mourn and grieve for our loved ones, people killed at the hands of the police, and we can also mourn and grieve for the loss of lives, specifically the police, who were killed. And we could still say that we believe Black Lives Matter and at the same time challenge this idea we had anything to do with that killing of the police. It became important to not back down from our demands whilst honoring people who lost their lives.

"I think what we recognized was that we can mourn and grieve for our loved ones, people killed at the hands of the police, and we can also mourn and grieve for the loss of lives, specifically the police, who were killed."

I want to talk about catalyzing change on a personal basis. For people who potentially live in districts where prison abolition may not be electorally viable, what steps do you think are most important to take right now to make lives better for people who are caught in the carceral pipelines?

Number one, know what your county jail population is. We confuse jails and prisons. Jails are usually run by the county. I think there's only a couple cities where the county doesn't run the jail, like New York. But in general, counties are running their jail systems. [They're] different than prisons: prisons are where people go when they are convicted; jails are where people go before they are convicted, and some of them are innocent, and they can't get out because they can't post bail. So, know your county jail population.

Number two, fight for bail reform. Fight for people to not have to serve time in jail if they are actually innocent.

Number three, fight for alternatives to incarceration. If you know that your jail population is mostly homeless people, mostly people with mental illness, mostly women who are domestic abuse survivors, then you have to question why they are in jail in the first place. Are we providing enough services for these people before they're criminalized?

What recommendations would you make to activists on campuses?

The first step is to make an announcement, whether it's to your student body government or a class announcement, that you're interested in a specific topic. Then try to meet with a bunch of people. Just have open call meetings about the work, about what you're interested in. See who you can get involved. See if there any clubs on campus that align with the work that you do. If they don't exist, then start one. And then from there, meet up with local organizations doing the work inside the communities. Sometimes colleges are really divorced from the local community, so you want to make sure that you do that.

GROUND

Connecticut's Small Farms Face an Uncertain Future

By **Arturo Pineda**

ROWS OF APPLE TREES line a hill rising gently over strawberry and blueberry beds. Bright patches of pumpkins dot the immaculate grounds of Rose's Berry Farm, a staple of Glastonbury, Connecticut since 1908. Once a small 20-acre fruit farm with no reputation, it is now, at 100 acres, recognized as Connecticut's largest blueberry farm.

The farm, which supplies much of the fresh produce served in Yale's dining halls, is a beloved stop on Yale Farm Tours, a program coordinated by Yale Dining Services to show students where their food comes from. Among Yale students and New Haveners, Rose's Berry Farm is famous for its Sunday morning tradition, "Breakfast with a View." Customers wait up to two hours to eat freshly baked Belgian waffles on an expansive deck overlooking dozens of acres of blueberry bushes and pear and apple trees. After breakfast, the visitors pick their own berries, and children from neighboring schools enjoy the playground.

From the outside, the farm seems to be thriving. People come and go, and Sandi Rose, the sole manager since her husband Henry's death in 2009, never stops moving. Business should be good—great, even—but it's not. It hasn't been good for a while.

IN CONNECTICUT, family farms are struggling to keep up with changing times. Members of an aging population, small farmers face a global market that demands levels of efficiency and production they are not equipped to meet. New regulations and a dwindling American agricultural labor force have motivated some to employ foreign workers through federal programs like the H-2A visa program, despite the high associated costs. Locally, the power of corporate distributors hasn't just made business less convenient—it has changed the way small farmers operate. Rose's farm is close to bankrupt.

"I haven't made money in the last three years," Rose told *The Politic*. "I'm barely making enough to break even and open the next year."

After more than 100 years in business, Rose sold half her farm to the town of Glastonbury in early June for 1.9 million dollars. The land included blueberry bushes, apple trees, and a raspberry patch.

A condition of the sale was that the town would continue to use the land for agriculture. Glastonbury Town Manager Richard J. Johnson agreed; he plans to work with nearby orchard managers and farmers to harvest the crops.

"I didn't want the land to stop being farmland," Rose said. "It was important that I honor Henry's legacy."

Rose, 64, knows that the rest of her farm is running out of time. Neither of her children will take her place, leaving her 14-year old grandson as the last possible successor.

"I don't want my grandson to have to take the farm on," Rose said. "I want him to have the choice of whether he wants to farm or not."

The problem of succession plagues farms across the state. According to a report from the American Farmland Trust and Land for Good, more than 90 percent of Connecticut's senior farmers (65 and older) do not have a young farm operator (under 45) working with them.

Among younger farmers, business seems to be better. Federal data shows that, on average, farmers under 45 netted 7,000 dollars more in 2017 than in 2016, while older farmers lost 13,000 dollars. Some have speculated that younger farmers have avoided competition by investing in niche products, but there's no definitive answer as to why they are faring better than their elders.

But the number of young farmers in Connecticut is dwindling—a serious concern, given that senior farmers constitute a third of all farmers in the state. Farmers under the age of 44

comprise just 12 percent of farmers in Connecticut. The average age of Connecticut farmers, census data shows, is 58.

VITAL PARTS OF American agriculture, family farms speckle the U.S. from coast to coast. In 2012, the U.S. Department of Agriculture (USDA) calculated that 96 percent of all farms in the country were family-owned. Most of them—roughly 90 percent—qualified as small farms, grossing less than 250,000 dollars annually in all food sales.

Under the Food Safety and Modernization Act (FSMA), passed in 2011, the Food and Drug Administration (FDA) has the power to regulate how food is picked, packaged, and processed. After the law passed, small farms were allowed more time than their larger counterparts to comply with the FDA's regulations—with the ultimate goal that all farms, large and small, would follow the same practices, under the same regulations.

Called a "sliding-scale" approach, the model appears to privilege small farms. In actuality, though, the policy burdens them by holding them to the same standards as large farms, even though it is unfeasible for them to operate in the same way because they have fewer resources.

For example, all farms will be required to use disposable, biodegradable shipping containers, which are too expensive for small farms to buy regularly. Under the new regulations, farmers must revamp their tracking systems to electronically document sales—but most small farms lack the equipment and the workforce required to update their systems.

The deadline is looming: Large farms had to comply with most of the requirements by January 2017, whereas most small farms had to comply by January 2018. Very small farms—under 20 acres of cropland—have until January 2019.

The sliding-scale approach was adopted in order to avoid a "one-size-fits-all" policy. An attempt to account for resource disparity among farmers, the law still holds all farmers to an almost identical set of protocols, ostensibly to ensure food safety.

But in Connecticut, one longtime food safety advocate has been hurt by the legislation. Doug Bussa, owner of Bussa Orchards, presides over 40 acres of fruit trees and manages under 200,000 dollars in gross sales per year. Bussa is Good Agricultural Practice (GAP) certified, which means he volunteered to have USDA officials inspect his farm's packaging, handling, and storing for safety. Before FSMA, GAP certification was a badge of honor.

Bussa expected the FSMA regulations to be a smooth transition; after all, he and the USDA had agreed the farm was small and safe. But in 2017, the regulations almost drove his farm to bankruptcy.

BUSSA ORCHARDS IS primarily a wholesale farm, with 90 percent of its product sold directly to big distributors. Freshpoint, one of the largest wholesale distributors in Connecticut, is Bussa's biggest buyer.

The Freshpoint warehouse complex is a 15-minute drive from the farm. Bussa used to pack up his apples in his pickup truck and drive there, but he can't do that anymore. The FDA does not allow produce to be transported even short distances without refrigeration. Bussa was forced to buy a refrigerated truck for 50,000 dollars to deliver his produce to Freshpoint.

"These rules don't make sense for me," he said. "If you're going across country or out-of-state, that makes sense. But I'm going right down the road."

Bussa hasn't thought much about being competitive in the market. It doesn't help that some regulations are changing or still aren't established, as is the case with agricultural water, or water used for farming. The FDA issued a proposal in Feb-



PHOTO ILLUSTRATIONS BY **SONALI DURHAM**

"IT'S HARD BEING A LITTLE GUY. YOU'RE SMALL BUT EXPECTED TO DO THE SAME THING AS A LARGER GROWER BUT WITH LE







ruary 2018, but it has not been finalized. Bussa would like to adapt accordingly, but he can't afford to make changes that he may have to reverse.

"It's hard being a little guy," he said. "You're small but expected to do the same thing as a larger grower, but with less resources. You just can't absorb that type of cost."

IN THE U.S., farms aren't just scrambling for funds. Too few Americans are willing to work long hours for the wages small farmers like Rose and Bussa can pay. As a result, more and more farmers are turning to guest workers to plant and harvest, according to federal data from the U.S. Office of Foreign Labor.

During the first three months of 2017, the Department of Labor approved applications to fill 69,272 farm jobs with workers on H-2A visas—documents that allow non-citizens to fill temporary agricultural jobs in the U.S.—marking an increase of 36 percent from 2016.

The H-2A visa program has been growing rapidly in recent years, as farmers struggle to recruit enough domestic workers to keep their farms running. Their dependence on H-2A has come with controversy. Advocates for American farm workers, such as Farmworker Justice, have condemned farmers who use the program for outsourcing domestic jobs and refusing to pay higher wages to American workers. Unlike many Midwestern states, where H-2A is popular, Connecticut has shown a shrinking dependence on guest workers. According to a 2013 report from the Connecticut Department of Labor, the New England Farm Workers Council estimated there were 7,000 guest workers in the state; three years later, the estimate dropped to just under 6,000.

High overhead expenses and standards designed to prevent exploitation of guest workers, such as a requirement that employers provide free transportation, are simply unfeasible for many small farmers in New England. Christina Teter, the owner of Mountain Orchard LLC in Granville, Massachusetts, estimated that overhead costs for one guest worker can range from 1,100 to 1,200 dollars, depending on the year, to pay for the visa, taxes, and paperwork done through the Department of Labor. Bussa reported similar expenses.

Mountain Orchard is a 52-acre farm that sells half of its produce wholesale and half to stores, farm stands, and the local college, Westfield State University. Though Mountain Orchard is located in Massachusetts, its fate is tied to the Connecticut market. (Teter deals exclusively with Connecticut-based Freshpoint for wholesale.) Less than ten miles beyond the state border, Mountain Orchard has been dubbed "local" by

ESS RESOURCES.

YOU JUST CAN'T ABSORB THAT TYPE OF COST.

Connecticut sellers.

Once the guest workers arrive, it only becomes harder to control labor expenses, Teter said. Under the Department of Labor's "50-percent rule," during the first half of a contract period with foreign workers on H-2A, a farmer must hire any U.S. worker that asks for a job, provided the worker is able and qualified. Even if the farm is fully staffed, the farmer is bound by law to hire the American applicant.

But farmers risk losing money when they choose to hire American workers, Teter said. And if they lose money that way, they are less likely to have enough funds to switch to H-2A. Farmers employing U.S. workers often set aside extra money to pay unqualified employees for jobs poorly done, Teter said. It's a lose-lose for the farmers—but it allows the Department of Labor to say that Americans still want agricultural jobs.

To Rose, the 50-percent rule is degrading. It makes the work of farmers and pickers seem easy, she said, when in actuality, the work takes practice and grit.

"The premise of the H-2A is that you are requesting 'unskilled' labor, but that's just not true," Rose said. "Picking various crops at a fast rate a certain way requires skill, but [the Department of Labor] doesn't want to recognize that because it makes Americans seem lazy."

Both Teter and Bussa continue to employ H-2A workers because foreign workers are a guaranteed labor force, despite the high costs. At both of their farms, labor-related costs account for half of all expenses.

Others have turned to undocumented workers, who will often work for lower wages. Across the country, undocumented immigrants working on American farms have reported wage theft and unhygienic living conditions. But threats of deportation and economic need often keep them at their jobs, according to studies by the Southern Poverty Law Center. Some farmers in Connecticut who have been reported for exploitation have turned to undocumented workers, too—perpetuating a cycle of immigrant worker abuse.

Connecticut farmers and workers alike worry what will happen to them in the coming years with Trump's strong anti-immigration stance, said Rose, many of whose employees are Hispanic. Even documented workers worry that they will be picked up by ICE because of the color of their skin or deported because of sudden changes in legislation.

WILLIAM DELLACAMERA, 38, is part of the new wave of farmers trying to make the market work for them. But corporate ownership of distributors has left DellaCamera with little power.

DellaCamera manages a 140-acre fruit and vegetable farm called Cecarelli Farms in Northford, Connecticut. Using a mixed-crop model, Cecarelli operates without a core cash crop, instead farming plots of different kinds of produce, from strawberries to cauliflower to potatoes. Although the farm is 140 acres, only 80 acres have been active since a recent scale-back.

The farm is known throughout the state for being on the cutting edge of innovation while also modeling natural, traditional farming practices. Before his death last January, former manager Nelson Cecarelli developed and popularized a deep-zone tilling technique in which seeds are planted at greater depths to reduce erosion and carbon dioxide emissions. Now, more than 40 farms across the state use his technique.

Despite Cecarelli Farms' success, DellaCamera noted that one of the biggest challenges facing farms like his is the loss of local distributors. Connecticut used to have multiple family-owned distributors working alongside family farms, but not anymore. Before Freshpoint existed, Fowler & Huntting Company Inc., a third-generation distributor in Hartford, provided personalized services to local farmers.

Founded in 1865, the company was run by the Yandow family. In 1994, Bill Yandow sold Fowler & Huntting to his four nephews, Kenneth, William, David, and Thomas. David Yandow was responsible for buying

from local farms and soon developed close relationships with the farmers.

When Nelson Cecarelli, the former manager of Cecarelli Farms, had extra produce, he could depend on David Yandow to take it off his hands, DellaCamera said. Yandow never turned Cecarelli down; he always found a way to accommodate his friends.

According to DellaCamera, dynamics between Fowler & Huntting and local farmers changed when Sysco Corporation, the parent company of Freshpoint, bought out Fowler & Huntting in 2006. The company adopted a more corporate model and stopped going the extra mile. Yandow wasn't buying extra produce like he used to.

Freshpoint is now the largest distributor of food in the state of Connecticut and controls much of the movement of local produce in the Greater Hartford area. Some farmers, like Stewart "Chip" Beckett of Beckett Farms, believe Freshpoint has too strong of a pull, especially in Hartford. Beckett cited the lack of major competitors and Freshpoint's plans to expand as evidence.

DellaCamera and Beckett both resent corporate power's influence on Connecticut farming, but they will continue to sell wholesale to Freshpoint. They have no choice, DellaCamera said: A Big Y supermarket will buy a box of squash for 10 dollars—double the amount Freshpoint will pay—but Big Y will only buy 25 boxes. Freshpoint will take 100.

To make money, DellaCamera has to balance direct retail to local stores with wholesale to Freshpoint. But Freshpoint isn't the only distributor in the state. Why does DellaCamera keep going back?

"Freshpoint is the most consistent distributor," he said. "I know that once I drop off my produce, I'll have my check in 12 days."

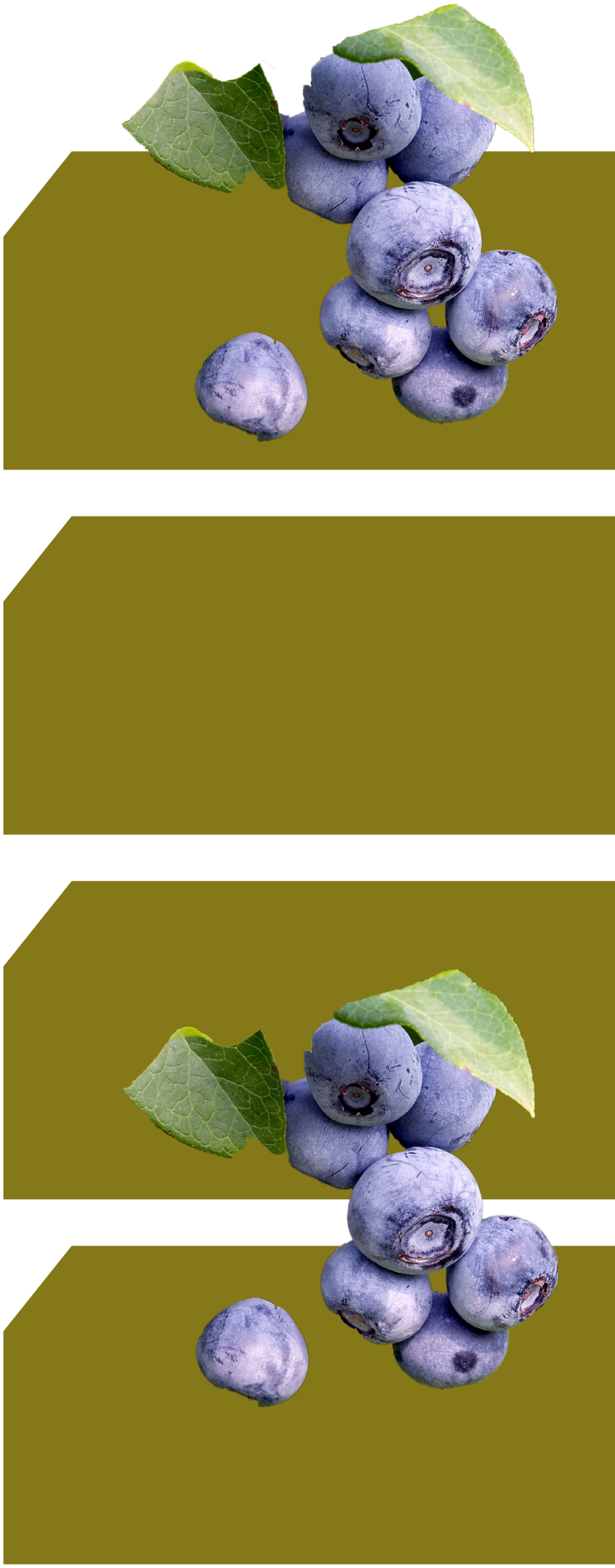
He has tried smaller distributors across the state, but they have proved less reliable. Sometimes the distributor's check would take 30 or 60 days to arrive, only for it to bounce. It wasn't worth the trouble of sacrificing money and valuable time to find another distributor.

"I can't make it without them," DellaCamera said of Freshpoint. If he ended his relationship with Freshpoint without a high-volume buyer to rely on, he worries future crop shortages would bankrupt him. "I need to keep my foot in the door."

ROSE, BUSSA, TETER, DellaCamera, and Beckett all know David Yandow, now the vice president of Freshpoint Connecticut, personally.

"The farmers are worried we've become too corporate," Yandow said. "That's a legitimate concern. I want them to remember that I spent most of my life advocating for local produce and built Freshpoint around local."

A month ago, Yandow took Rose out to dinner to



learn about the sale of her farm and to offer help. He went boating with Will last summer. Farmers agree that Yandow genuinely cares about them and tries to help them whenever he can.

"We're trying to be as a fair as possible to the farmers," Yandow said. Freshpoint's website is plastered with advertisements about local food and the company's slogan, "local flavor." Under the "Meet the Farmer" tab, website visitors can read short biographies about all the farmers who partner with Freshpoint. Yandow brought the passion he developed for local food at Fowler & Huntting to his work at Freshpoint. But no amount of advertising has softened the bottom line: money.

"Everybody wants a million dollars for their produce," Yandow said. "I get it, but pricing isn't really up to me or Freshpoint. The market dictates the price."

Identifying a single market that's setting prices can be tricky. U.S. agriculture has globalized, Yandow explained. In 2016, the Department of Agriculture estimated that more than half of all fruit and a third of all vegetables were imported, with much of the produce coming from heavy-hitting Latin America and Canada. Small American farms compete with big American farms, but both compete with international powerhouses.

"We try to remind our buyers that the produce is local," Yandow said. "But that doesn't matter if the market is flooded and there are cheaper options out there."

Knowing local small farmers are fighting an uphill battle, Yandow had a special dock built at the Hartford company headquarters specifically for local farmers. There, they can bypass the usual lines and unload their product without a long wait. But Yandow's efforts haven't been enough. Small farms keep losing money.

Earlier this year, both Freshpoint and Sardilli Produce & Dairy Co., a milk and dairy distributor, submitted proposals to build new distribution centers in Hartford's South Meadows, according to the Capital Region Development Authority. In June, Sardilli withdrew its application, leaving Freshpoint to win the bid, according to the *Hartford Courant*.

Yandow hopes that the expansion, which would add 125 jobs, will help him better support local small farmers. He hopes to acquire a flash freezer that would hold farmers' leftover produce for a season. That way, even if a year's crop were poor, farmers would have a consistent source of income.

Still, Yandow is concerned about the future of small farms. He knows that the market price is just one factor in what keeps a farm open; the rest, he said, is out of his hands.

"I don't know if they're going to be around for long," he said. "Right now, some of them are just waiting to see if this year is going to be good enough to open up next year."

WITH THE 2012 Farmland Restoration Program, Connecticut Governor Dannel Malloy has tried to revitalize the state's agriculture. For the past six years, the program has provided matching monetary support to farmers to reclaim fallow farmland and restore it. Farms can qualify to receive up to 20,000 dollars, according to the Connecticut Department of Agriculture.

Though it's difficult to predict the future of small farming, there's a resilient group of Connecticut farmers who don't plan on giving up anytime soon.

In spite of all the obstacles—regulations that benefit large farms, funds, workers, a global market—Doug Bussa believes that small farming will continue to exist as long as familiar faces like Yandow keep working at places like Freshpoint. Personnel turnover could spell disaster, but for now, Bussa's not too worried. Sandi Rose doesn't think small farming is going to fade away, either. But farmers will have to evolve. She believes small farms will continue to exist because they're adaptable.

"Farming is going to be different in the future," Rose said. "It might not be the farming we're used to. But we'll change to match."

Debating Discrimination

The Fight Over Ivy League Affirmative Action

BY **IAN MOREAU**

MARK HAS A LOT GOING for him. A member of America's mythical "upper-middle class," his life has been one of privilege and success. The son of well-off Bay Area professionals, he attended a competitive public high school before securing a highly-coveted spot here at Yale. Now, with college graduation just six months away, he plans on working at Facebook, where his starting salary will dwarf the average annual income of the typical American. For the foreseeable future, his financial security is all but assured.

Mark, whose name has been changed for the sake of his privacy, knows all this. Self-aware, amiable, and deliberate with his words, he is no caricature of Ivy League privilege. He dresses modestly (plain t-shirts, blue jeans) and sports Snowden-style rectangular glasses. He acknowledges his good fortune, and is, above all else, likable.

In spite of his affluent background, some Americans would argue that Mark, a Chinese American, should consider himself especially lucky to be attending a school like Yale. In their eyes, the college admissions process subjects Asian-American students like Mark to racially discriminatory practices (namely, affirmative action), putting them at a serious disadvantage. Some are even framing the issue as the

next great American battle over civil rights—with young Asian Americans like Mark at its center.

IN NOVEMBER 2014, the anti-affirmative action group Students for Fair Admissions (SFFA) slammed Harvard with a lawsuit alleging a pattern of discrimination against Asian-American applicants, something many white conservatives and Asian Americans have long suspected. In August 2018, the Department of Justice, led by Attorney General Jeff Sessions, lent its support to the more than 20,000 plaintiffs—students, parents, and others—in the case.

Around the same time, numerous Asian-American civil rights and advocacy organizations, including the Asian American Coalition for Education (AACE), filed a series of complaints against elite universities with the federal government. In response, the Department of Justice and Department of Education's Office of Civil Rights launched two joint investigations into the admissions practices of Harvard and Yale, triggering a storm of media coverage and an uptick in student activism on college campuses.

Some would point to substantial data that corroborates their claims. A 2008 study published in *InterActions: UCLA Journal of Education and Information Studies* revealed that state bans on affirmative action policies at public universities led to increases in Asian Americans' odds of acceptance. Much of the study examined admissions data from California, where affirmative action was banned through a 1996 state referendum. At the University of California, Berkeley, the share of Asian-American first-years rose from roughly 37 percent in 1995 to roughly 47 percent in 2005. In an interview with *The Chronicle of Higher Education,* David Colburn, a former provost at the University of Florida and one of the study's authors, stated, "Asian Americans were discriminated against under an affirmative-action system."

But Brian Taylor, managing director of Ivy Coach, an elite college admissions counseling firm, claims the issue is more complex.

Taylor told *The Politic*, "Asian-American applicants so often present similar profiles, and in many instances, I would argue that this profile is a template profile. A Chinese-American student who excels in math and in a string instrument and runs track—it's a profile that college admissions officers have seen before. It doesn't 'wow' them."

Taylor said that Asian-American applicants are primarily put at a disadvantage when they don't present themselves as unique. "That's true of Asian-American applicants, it's true of Caucasian applicants, African-American applicants," he insisted. "When a female Indian-American applicant presents a profile where they excel in engineering or they want to be a doctor and they do classical Indian dance," he said, admissions officers "have seen that profile so many times before." Rather than focusing on possible racial discrimination, Taylor advises his clients to present themselves as distinct individuals. His advice is simple: be interesting.

Mark largely agreed with Taylor. Describing his Bay Area high school in an interview with *The Politic*, he explained how the stereotype of the STEM-focused East Asian student contains some degree of truth. According to Mark, many Chinese families in the Bay Area are remarkably similar, with highly educated immigrant parents who push their kids towards a narrow set of academic and extracurricular pursuits.

"Although it's obviously not true of every student, when the stereotype is ingrained deeply enough in the culture, it is necessary to do some things to buck that trend," said Mark. "When you're dealing with so many high-achieving students who look very similar on paper and you have a very limited number of spots, it eventually comes down to this deep question of differentiation."

MANGA ANANTATMULA VEHEMENTLY REJECTS the idea that most Asians fit into "templates." A Hindu activist who works as an acquisitions consultant for the U.S. Army, Anantatmula has almost two decades of experience managing projects and working with federal agencies. Now a member of the AACE Board of Directors, she has recently turned her attention to the college admissions practices she views as unjust.

In an interview with *The Politic*, Anantatmula pointed to Title VI of the Civil Rights Act of 1964, which prohibits institutions receiving federal funds, like Harvard and Yale, from discriminating on the basis of race. She further argued that race-conscious admissions is unconstitutional and violates the Fourteenth Amendment, which enshrines equal protection under the law. "When there is a constitutional violation," she said, "that's where the clock stops."

AACE President Yukong Zhao echoed Anantatmula's statements in a separate interview. "It's really a moral issue," he said. "It's racial discrimination, explicitly banned by the Civil Rights Act."

Envisioning a more "merit-based" admissions process, AACE has sought to abolish race-conscious admissions policies since the group was founded in 2014. Alongside groups like Students for Fair Admissions, AACE has been at the forefront of the current controversy surrounding Harvard and Yale.

This isn't the first time, however, that affirmative action policies at universities have come under fire. Conservative and anti-affirmative action activists have been working through both courts and popular referendums for decades, successfully banning race-conscious admissions in states like California, Florida, and Michigan.

Given that past efforts have solely focused on public universities, the Harvard lawsuit and joint investigations mark the first time that the admissions policies of elite private institutions like Harvard and Yale have been placed under the proverbial legal microscope.



Historically, most complaints of race-based discrimination have been filed by white plaintiffs. After Abigail Fisher, a white woman, was rejected by the University of Texas in 2008, she unsuccessfully attempted to overturn the university's affirmative action policies in two cases that eventually reached the Supreme Court. Bert Rein, the seasoned lawyer who represented her both times, firmly believes that the facts are on AACE's side in the case of both Harvard and Yale.

Referencing the number of Asian admits at California's universities before and after the 1996 referendum, Rein asserted that affirmative action policies have been proven to significantly harm Asian Americans. "With Harvard and Yale, if you look at the scores, the grades, as much objective evidence as you can get, the performance of the Asian admits is way above the average," Rein told *The Politic*. "So the question is: why are you turning away so many?"

Kirk Kolbo, who represented plaintiffs challenging the University of Michigan's affirmative action policies in two Supreme Court cases, agreed. He believes Asian applicants are held to higher standards due to their high academic achievements. "It's like 50 years ago, when Harvard had a quota when they didn't want as many Jewish students," he said. "That's how they established the limit. They basically had separate admissions standards based on your race."

TREVOR, A BLACK YALE STUDENT and dedicated activist, is accustomed to discussing the delicate intersections of race and politics, especially with people of different viewpoints. (Like Mark, Trevor spoke on the condition of anonymity, citing the heated controversy surrounding affirmative action.) As sharp as he is unapologetic, he carries on conversations with a singular purpose and precision—and refuses to accept any slandering of affirmative action.

"I believe in diversity as a categorical and objective good," Trevor said. "The institutions that we support and attend should generally look like the people that they draw from. To me, Yale should look like America."

Labelling diversity a "convenient pretense" for anti-Asian discrimination, AACE repudiates such arguments touted by supporters of race-conscious admissions. When pressed on the issue, Zhao cited a 2007 study published in the *American Journal of Education* that found over 40 percent of black Ivy League students were foreigners. Anantatmula, referencing the same study, asserted that many black international students come from wealthy African families. She believes the diversity cultivated by affirmative action at schools like Harvard and Yale is, for Americans of color, hollow. "[These policies] are definitely not serving the interests of the United States' minority communities," she said.

Trevor disagrees, contending that affirmative action is a

useful tool for counteracting racialized inequities that have been entrenched in America's institutions for centuries.

"Many students of color are attending incredibly underfunded schools in cities and towns across America," Trevor observed. He said that many face structural disadvantages and a lack of resources that make them "appear less smart or less capable in the eyes of the supposedly objective testing system."

Kolbo, however, noted that arguments like Trevor's—which hails affirmative action as a socially corrective tool—aren't legally relevant. "That's never been a rationale that's been accepted by the courts," he said. Referencing *Gratz v. Bollinger*, one of the University of Michigan cases, he said, "The courts didn't accept the argument that remedying societal discrimination is a grounds for separate admissions standards, so I don't accept that as a valid theory."

But Trevor is more interested in justice than legalism or constitutionality. "Affirmative action exists in this much broader structure of racism in the United States," he said.

Though notably less enthusiastic about race-conscious admissions, Mark is also concerned with issues of justice. "The method of using race-based preferences is effectively a form of racial discrimination. Just because you're using it to fight existing racial discrimination doesn't make it just," he said. "But at the same time, these societal problems are real, so leaving them alone and pretending they don't exist is, I think, more unjust."

ALTHOUGH HE STRONGLY SUPPORTS affirmative action, Trevor also believes that Asian Americans are victims of racial discrimination. Unlike AACE, however, Trevor attributes this discrimination to implicit racial prejudices rather than affirmative action policies.

Trevor argued that both the "model minority myth" and stereotypes regarding Asian academic overachievement have proven incredibly harmful. "To some degree, Harvard is saying, 'Yes, this person might be smart, this person might have done well on their SAT and have a high GPA, but they have no personality.' Where does that come from other than blatant racism?" he said.

Instead of focusing on race-conscious admissions, Trevor thinks those concerned with fair admissions policies should be seeking to dismantle legacy admissions. "These universities could accept a lot more African-American and Asian students if they accepted less white students grandfathered into the process through legacy admissions," he said.

And many members of AACE would agree. Zhao strongly condemned legacy admissions at Ivy League universities, but also posed a question for those concerned with the welfare of America's other minorities:

"If Harvard and Yale really cared about African-American and Hispanic students," Zhao asked, "why aren't they giving these legacy spots to minority students?"

PROSPECTS LOOK GRIM for supporters of race-conscious admissions. With AACE and SFFA enjoying the Trump administration's support, college admissions consultants and legal experts alike expect a favorable outcome for the two groups.

"They're enjoying a perfect storm right now," Taylor, managing director of Ivy Coach, said.

Rein agreed, explaining that the Trump administration could conclude that Harvard and Yale are violating the Civil Rights Act with their affirmative action policies and threaten to cut off federal funding.

Further, he predicted that if *Students for Fair Admissions v. Harvard* were to reach the Supreme Court, the outcome would likely favor SFFA. He attributed this to conservative Justice Brett Kavanaugh replacing Justice Anthony Kennedy, who crucially voted to uphold the University of Texas' affirmative action policy in 2016. "Like it or not," Rein said, "the reality is that when these cases get to the Supreme Court, the vote is not going to be the same as it was before."

Taylor concurred.

"With the appointment of Justice Kavanaugh, I think affirmative action will be all but over by 2020," he said.

Despite the dim future affirmative action faces, Trevor holds tightly to his principles. At the end of his interview, he reflected on affirmative action as a small but crucial aspect of the endless battle against systemic racism in America.

He said, "The gains it has made, albeit not large, are, in fact, very worthwhile in the grand scheme of things."



A Chance at Closure

Repatriation of American Remains from North Korea Offers Hope

BY **ISABELLE RHEE**

On January 13, 2018, Hawaii residents woke to a jarring alert on their cell phones and television screens.

"BALLISTIC MISSILE THREAT BOUND TO HAWAII. SEEK IMMEDIATE SHELTER. THIS IS NOT A DRILL."

I remember it clearly. My father woke me up in a frenzy after hearing news of an imminent North Korean missile attack, and for the next 38 minutes, panic ensued as my family rushed to close all the windows in our house. Eventually, we received word that the alert was, in fact, a false alarm.

We didn't give the missile alert much thought after that. We considered the mishap an unfortunate yet isolated incident;



life went on as usual. In June 2018, I visited my grandparents in Daegu, South Korea, where marathoning K-drama series, exploring the city's historic alleyways, and indulging myself in Korean barbeque and street foods have defined my summers for the past decade.

But this summer was different. On June 12, 2018, from my grandparents' living room, my family and I watched President Donald Trump and North Korean Supreme Leader Kim Jong-un shake hands at Singapore's Capella Hotel, the first time a sitting U.S. president has done so with a North Korean leader.

According to Trump and Kim's joint statement, the Singapore Summit was "a comprehensive, in-depth, and sincere exchange of opinions" concerning U.S.-North Korea relations, aimed at "the building of a lasting and robust peace regime on the Korean Peninsula." While reporters were eager to cover its implications for nuclear disarmament, the statement's last objective—the fourth bullet point on a roughly 400-word document—went largely unnoticed.

The final goal outlined in the Singapore Summit called for a mutual commitment to recover the remains of U.S. soldiers missing from the Korean War. A process that first began in 1990, the repatriation of American remains in North Korea is nothing new. Yet, repatriation efforts were notably halted in 2005 during the Bush presidency, the suspension attributable to security concerns over North Korea's nuclear weapon development. Since then, zero sets of American remains were returned to the U.S.—until last July, when the transfer of remains resumed for the first time in 13 years.

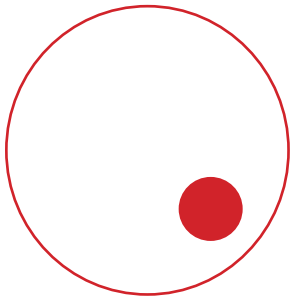
The most recent remains transfer occurred on July 27, 2018, exactly 65 years after North Korean, Chinese, and U.S.-led United Nations forces signed an agreement that effectively halted the Korean War with a ceasefire. The repatriation mission was negotiated between the North Korean military and the U.S. Department of Defense. A team of lab managers from the Defense POW/MIA Accounting Agency (DPAA) and anthropologists from the Korean War Project, a subgroup of the DPAA, led the repatriation efforts. They received the 55 boxes of American remains firsthand from the North Korean military and inspected the remains before transferring them to the U.S. for further analysis.

In an interview with *The Politic*, Jennie Jin, the current director of the Korean War Project, recalled traveling to North Korea in July for the first time with her team of anthropologists.

"Flying into North Korea was especially memorable because both my grandparents from my father's and mother's sides were from North Korea," Jin said, noting that she was only speaking for herself and not for the Korean War Project. "We were in Wonsan—a major port city on the east coast of North Korea—for only three hours, but it was still a very emotional experience because that's where my maternal grandmother was captured by the North Koreans during the war."

After accepting the remains and conducting a preliminary review in Wonsan, Jin and her team relocated to an American air base in Osan, South Korea. There, the team spent two full days unpacking and identifying the skeletal parts in the boxes of remains.

By the end of the analysis, they hope to determine how many indi-



viduals were present in each box. According to Jin, 55 boxes of remains do not necessarily equal 55 different individuals. Co-mingling, she said, is likely, meaning multiple individuals' remains could be present in a single box.

After taking measurements, the Korean War Project team began a DNA sampling of the bones, which, according to Jin, will take weeks—possibly months—to complete. After undergoing initial analysis in Hawaii, the samples will be sent to the Armed Forces DNA Identification Laboratory (AFDIL) in Washington, D.C, where scientists will compare the results of the DNA tests to family reference samples. Ultimately, the goal of the project is to match all the bones to DNA samples of families who lost loved ones during the Korean War.

The project's success hinges on factors like the presence of dental records, the availability of family DNA samples, and the types of bones involved. (Certain bones, like clavicles, can be more easily matched to an individual than others.) DNA analysis is a rate-limiting factor. Rick Downes, the executive director of the Coalition for Families of Korean and Cold War POW/MIAs, told *The Politic*, "DNA identification can take months alone. Some men will be identified within the next few months; others will take much longer."

Four months after the July 27 remains transfer, only two individuals have been identified by the DPAA's laboratories in Hawaii. In both cases, special conditions aided the process: in one box was a dog tag; in the other, the serviceman identified was especially tall. But for families whose relatives weren't gifted with unusual physical features or IDs at their times of death, there isn't yet an end in sight.

Following the remains transfer, liberal media outlets, such as MSNBC and *The Washington Post*, dismissed the effort as a mere search for bones that contributed nothing to the broader objective of North Korea's denuclearization. By contrast, Fox News and op-eds in other conservative American news outlets lauded Trump's efforts to bring peace to the Korean Peninsula.

Despite the political divide surrounding the remains recovery, individuals like Jin and Downes, whose own father went missing in Korea in 1952, speak to its humanitarian value.

"We're only going to learn the answer to one man's fate by pursuing them all," Downes said. "The government is not going to spend tens of millions of dollars looking for my dad, but they will spend it to look for all of the men."

To family members of soldiers who went missing in action, the repatriation process in North Korea provides a sense of "hope with caution," Downes explained. He noted that the recent transfer of 55 boxes accounts for only one percent of the approximately 7,000 Korean War veterans—both abroad and buried in Hawaii's Punchbowl National Cemetery—that have yet to be identified. "You don't want to get overly hopeful because we have had disappointments throughout the decades," he cautioned.

Yet for Downes, the ongoing repatriation process signifies the "hope that it will be our loved one found," he said, "and the feeling of joy when another family gets the answer that they've been hoping for."

Jin said, "Politics aside, this will bring some closure to the families who have been waiting for a very long time."

Jin believes the repatriation mission is particularly relevant to young Americans. The men who lost their lives during the Korean War—many of whom had never heard of Korea before leaving to fight there—were mostly between the ages of 18 and 23. "Most of them were drafted, went to war, and never made it back home," Jin said. "So it's an obligation to bring them back home—that's the humanitarian side of why we should care."

> "When you live in Korea, the miniscule possibility of reducing war right in your backyard—it *is* something."

Repatriation efforts and U.S.-North Korea relations often closely align. While the first repatriation efforts began in 1990, the operations were halted multiple times, usually when U.S.-North Korea relations were at historic lows.

Most notably, in 2005, the U.S. government pulled the Korean War Project team from North Korea, citing safety concerns following the failure of the six-party talks—a series of negotiations between the U.S., the two Koreas, Japan, Russia, and China aimed at enacting a peaceful resolution to North Korea's nuclear weapons program. Although the repatriation process has a rocky history, the most recent remains handoff can be compared to similar negotiations in the past that have led to positive outcomes.

The 1994 repatriation of American remains from the Vietnam War played a critical role in President Bill Clinton's decision to lift a trade embargo against Vietnam. The following year, Clinton announced the normalization of diplomatic relations with Vietnam, breaking two decades of severed ties.

"Although [the remains transfer] may look trivial to some of the people in the hub of politics, it's important to look at what happened in Vietnam and how we reestablished a relationship with a country we fought against," Jin maintained.

Engaging with North Korea on the transfer of American remains could also serve as a way for the U.S. to mitigate Korea-related policy crises. Mickey Bergman, vice president and executive director of the Richardson Center for Global Engagement, is familiar with negotiations between the two countries regarding remains repatriation. He explained to *The Politic* that the remains negotiation makes the U.S.-North Korea relationship "thicker" than a "single thread" dependent on the success of nuclear negotiations.

"If we have a fight over the issue of denuclearization, we still have that channel working," he said.

As a left-leaning Korean American whose great-grandparents fled North Korea just prior to the war, I find myself caught between two conflicting dialogues regarding the transfer of Korean War remains. The liberal American narratives I consume are skeptical that the remains transfer could ease political tensions. But my family members in South Korea support the repatriation efforts. In fact, for many South Korean citizens whose families were relocated, divided, and subjected to unimaginable hardships during the war, the Singapore Summit was a symbol of hope.

Won-ho Park, professor of political science at Seoul National University, agreed that the remains negotiations have struck many South Koreans as a step forward. "When you live in Korea, the miniscule possibility of reducing war right in your backyard—it *is* something," Park said. "I think the Korean public opinion is responding to that."

Public views on the Singapore Summit in South Korea are creating "a strange cross-wiring of liberals and conservatives," Park added, with most Korean liberals supporting any form of peace talks involving the North, despite Trump's reckless diplomacy.

"Somebody has to take a leap, which is something you don't normally see in traditional diplomacy," Park said. "But if there is someone who can do that, it's probably Trump. That's the way that most Koreans are thinking right now."

The stakes of diplomacy between North Korea and South Korea are high; without a formal peace agreement, the two Koreas are technically still at war. When it comes to imagining the number of Korean deaths during the war, Bergman said, "most Americans do not know, and the answer is in the millions." According to some estimates, the "Forgotten War," as Americans colloquially describe it, had a death toll of 4.5 million North and South Korean soldiers and civilians.

"When Americans think about the Korean War, they think, 'This was a small war between World War II and Vietnam.' And that's a mismatch in the American psyche of understanding," Bergman said. "With 4.5 million people dead, that means that every single family [in Korea] had suffered casualties."

When thinking about the two Koreas' diverging societies, I am often reminded of a photograph taken at night from outer space that demonstrates the stark contrast between the two nations. On the southern side of the Demilitarized Zone, the land is awash in bright lights, while the northern half is cloaked in darkness. Each year, thousands of young men in both nations are conscripted into the military and charged with the defense of their half. Since the peak of North Korea's crippling famine in the late 1990s, thirty thousand North Koreans have risked their lives to defect to the South. And while South Korea is known on the global stage as a leading producer of technology and pop culture, the North remains infamous for its human rights violations. The costs of an unfinished war are immeasurable.

It is impossible to predict when and if the Korean Peninsula will ever be reunited, if the North will ever denuclearize, and if an actual missile attack will ever reach the shores of Hawaii. Meanwhile, the descendants of fallen soldiers, families split by the 38th parallel, and elders who can still remember life in an undivided Korea continue to grapple with the legacy of war. For many of them, the transfer of remains is a chance at some closure.

I find myself caught between two conflicting dialogues regarding the transfer of Korean War remains.

A Milgram Experiment for 2018

Sacha Baron Cohen Asks, *Who is America?*

By **Eric Wallach**



IN JULY 1961, scientists told 40 New Haven men to administer electric shocks to other men. The shocks they ordered increased in voltage: all of the participants continued to 300 volts; 65 percent dealt the most powerful shock, 450 volts, labelled "XXX."

Participants in Yale psychologist Stanley Milgram's famous experiment, they proved a dismal point: people are willing to obey authority figures even when they receive orders that conflict with their moral judgements.

Milgram and his team told the subjects to think of themselves as teachers, inflicting electric shocks on volunteers to help them complete a memory task. In reality, the volunteers were actors, and the electric shocks were not real.

Shockingly, the "teachers" discarded their moral intuitions and values almost immediately when they were given unethical instructions by authority figures. Even as the actors screamed and cried for help, the subjects continued to administer the fake electric shocks.

Fifty-seven years later, actor and producer Sacha Baron Cohen unintentionally gives us an imperfect yet staggering replication of Milgram's work. Baron Cohen's Showtime series, *Who Is America?*, provides an uncomfortable, candid exposé of the American psyche by showing how easily humans are manipulated. While the Milgram Experiment revealed participants' willingness to administer electric shocks to *others*, *Who Is America?* exposes how easily participants will blindly shock *themselves*—as well as the institutions they represent and, most importantly, their own nation.

Baron Cohen is famous for using a set of absurd personalities to trick unsuspecting public figures into embarrassing themselves on camera. After rising to fame on *The 11 O'Clock Show* (1998), he soon launched *Da Ali G Show* (2000), in which he notoriously pranked President Donald Trump into supporting the creation of drippage-stopping "ice cream gloves." Next, Baron Cohen released *Borat* (2006), a comedic mockumentary of American culture, which gained renown for exposing the veiled racism of unsuspecting Americans, denouncing everyone from three University of Southern California frat bros to an entire Virginia rodeo crowd. In addition to his most well-known roles, Baron Cohen has portrayed the flamboyant Austrian fashionista Brüno in the eponymous 2009 film and Admiral General Aladeen, a dictator attempting to safeguard his nation's authoritarian regime, in *The Dictator* (2012). The recipient of numerous awards—including two BAFTA awards (both in 2001), a Golden Globe for Best Actor (2007), an MTV Movie Award for Best Comedic Performance (2007), and the British Outstanding Achievement Award (2013)—Baron Cohen even headlined Harvard's 2004 commencement as Ali G.

From the outset of *Who Is America?*, Baron Cohen argues that viewers should be conscious of blind idealizations of the United States. The show's introductory sequence begins with a montage of Americana: scenes of John F. Kennedy and Franklin D. Roosevelt's inaugural addresses, Jackie Robinson stealing home plate, and Ronald Reagan's "Tear down this wall!" speech. Toward the end of the sequence, the clips devolve into chaos: DJ Shub interjects with his frenzied and hyperactive "Indomitable," while President Trump abruptly enters the scene and mocks a reporter with a disability by faking a seizure.

In some ways, the sequence also mocks the depictions of American individualism and greatness that preceded Trump's antics. Through this stark contrast, Baron Cohen thrusts us back into reality, criticizing our selective attention to America's best features while whiting out and absolving ourselves of responsibility for its worst.

To uncover these hypocrisies, Baron Cohen poses as a series of characters, each meant to dupe his interviewees into exposing—for better or worse—their true selves. He cycles through the identities of Billy Wayne Ruddick Jr., Ph.D., a far-right conspiracy theorist and cultural commentator; Dr. Nira Cain-N'Degeocello, a proudly apologetic, white, cisgender, heterosexual, liberal journalist for NPR; Rick Sherman, a British ex-con artist and producer; Erran Morad, an authoritative Israeli anti-terrorism expert; Gio Monaldo, the Dan Bilzerian of Italian playboy-photographers; and OMGWhizzBoyOMG!, a Finnish YouTuber. In this one-sided game, by strategically embodying different characters and adopting the particular qualities and beliefs that best elicit information, Baron Cohen sneakily gains the upper hand.

The grand irony of the show lies in viewers' failure to recognize their own complicity.

Consider the following scene: Baron Cohen, under the guise of Gio Monaldo, guides former *Bache-*

lorette prima donna, Corinne Olympios, into concocting a story about her monthlong charitable work in Sierra Leone during the Ebola crisis.

Leaning forward as the coattails of his blazer spill out from his director's chair, Baron Cohen-as-Gio rhythmically moves his hands. Taken separately, each part of his outfit screams "imposter"—the white blazer with pink shorts, the overabundance of bracelets around his arm, and the cross that hangs down to his waistline like a tie. Regarded as a whole, however, his outfit looks so outlandish that it must be real—the artistic genius of someone who has transcended stylistic rules.

"How long were you in Sierra Leone fighting this Ebola crisis?" Gio asks.

Awkwardly picking at her nail polish, Olympios glances around the room before nervously fixing her eyes on Gio. "Um…" She momentarily hesitates. "I was there for about a week."

"Oh, amazing!" Gio quickly responds. "It's great!" he adds, unable in these last words to resist blending pseudo-Italian and Wadiyan, the native tongue of Admiral General Aladeen from *The Dictator.*

The camera slowly zooms in on Olympios' stoic face, keeping Gio's exaggerated gestures in the periphery. Lowering his volume while accelerating his tempo, Gio replies, "Is it possible to say you were there for a month? Because the thing was about three months. So…"

Almost immediately, Olympios breaks from her expressionless look—the viewer hoping she will refuse to be complicit in Gio's devilish fairytale. With a sense of gravity, she chimes in, "O.K. Yeah, but they're gonna know that I wasn't there."

Gio reassures her. She need not worry: he "runs the charity" she would claim she'd been working for. Olympios straightens in her chair and nods, looks into his eyes, and tells him she was "there for about a month."

Time and again, Baron Cohen bends his interviewees to his will—from Olympios to former Vice President Dick Cheney, who confessed to ordering torture, to former Georgia State Representative Jason Spencer, who screamed the N-word.

Though viewers routinely condemn Baron Cohen's interviewees, the grand irony of the show lies in viewers' failure to recognize their own complicity. Like an episode of *Black Mirror*, the show implicates its viewership as much as its subjects.

Consider a concrete example: an NPR writer named Linda Holmes criticized Baron Cohen's portrayal of Dr. Nira Cain-N'Degeocello, the NPR journalist, for being an overused, and therefore unamusing, caricature of leftist identity politics. "I'm sorry to say that these indeed are the jokes, folks," she writes.

In her criticism, Holmes joined the ranks of public figures whose sense of humor, with its thousand-yard restraining order on jokes like the ones in *Who is America?*, Baron Cohen wishes to caricature. Without formally interviewing Holmes, Baron Cohen achieves exactly that. She falls for his bait.

Holmes is not alone. Viewers endlessly prey on the character flaws of Baron Cohen's victims. Are Baron Cohen's viewers watching in good faith, or do they watch to validate themselves? Do they want to do good deeds, or do they just want to distance themselves from bad ones?

In the Milgram Experiment, "authority figures" manipulated average citizens to inflict pain on their peers. In *Who Is America?*, Baron Cohen takes the experiment further, placing the American political and cultural elite in the hot seat, and, in doing so, implicating the viewer, too. In Baron Cohen's eyes, it's not just average Americans—the Kingsman Arizonans, the underground rappers, the independent art curators—that blindly follow authority; it's also the Cheneys and the Spencers. From start to finish, Baron Cohen's satire is spectacularly uncomfortable because its message is so clear: that you can look like Kennedy on paper while acting like Trump in the locker room; that America can be presidential while also being deplorable; that you, the viewer, could be next.

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on-line pre-view

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